

#Muthoot Blue



8 MILLION
STORIES.
₹1,68,474 Cr
disbursed across India.



FINANCIAL RESULTS HIGHLIGHTS

STANDALONE (Annual year-on-year basis)				CONSOLIDATED (Annual year-on-year basis)			
FY PERFORMANCE	FY'26	FY'25	% YoY GROWTH	FY'26	FY'25	% YoY GROWTH	
Disbursement (Cr) (including co-lending)	1,58,062.20	66,277.31	138.49	1,68,474.35	76,050.02	121.53	
AUM (Cr)	56,185.10	32,055.17	75.28	73,448.82	46,943.89	56.46	
Loan Asset (Cr)	46,193.29	26,031.65	77.45	60,103.86	37,764.66	59.15	
Revenue (Cr)	8,364.28	5,550.53	50.69	11,227.80	8,511.57	31.91	
Net NPA (Cr)	0.57%	1.28%	71 bps	0.73%	1.24%	51 bps	
PAT (Cr)	1,640.21	787.15	108.37	1,847.62	607.99	203.89	
ROA	4.16%	2.95%	121 bps	3.47%	1.55%	192 bps	
EPS (Rs)	84.61	40.64	108.21	90.58	36.70	146.81	

Extract of audited standalone & consolidated financial results for the year ended 31st March 2026. For more information, please visit www.muthootfincorp.com



Top 50
India's Best
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2026

5,600+
Branches
47,000+
Muthootians

8 MILLION
Families Served
4.7 MILLION+
Women Customers*



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Includes subsidiaries.
T & C apply.

*Women customers served is the total unique women customers who have transacted with us in FY '26.

Domestic, overseas airfares on the rise since March on higher costs, demand

HIGH-FLYING. Confidence in cross-border travel rising with users spending more on premium experiences

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Airfares across domestic as well as international routes in India have risen on a sequential basis since March, according to datasets analysed by *businessline*, with international sectors witnessing a sharper increase amid higher operational costs and strong summer travel demand.

ABV, KEY METRIC
Pricing trends shared by on-line travel agencies ixigo, Cleartrip and Wego showed that international average booking values (ABV) and route-level fares continued to rise through April and May.

In simple terms, ABV is the total amount of money a traveller spends on a single transaction, serving as a key metric for how much revenue a platform or airline generates per confirmed reservation. Data is not avail-

able for the North American routes as domestic airlines have curtailed operations and comparable figures cannot be obtained.

According to data shared by Wego, international ABVs increased significantly from approximately ₹22,700 in February to over ₹32,600 in May. Domestic ABVs rose at a slower pace from around ₹8,800 to ₹9,400 during the same period.

Data released by Cleartrip showed that the average international airfare for April/May stood at ₹74,500, compared with ₹52,000 in the corresponding period last year.

DOMESTIC FARES
Additionally, domestic airfare averaged ₹8,450 against ₹5,850 a year earlier. The sharper rise in international ABV reflected growing traveller confidence in cross-border travel, said Bernard Corraya, General Manager, Wego, adding that users were spending more on

PRICEY TRAVEL

- Average international airfare for April/May 2026 stood at ₹74,500, compared with ₹52,000 last year
- Airfares on the Mumbai-New Delhi route increased from ₹6,530 in March to ₹7,526 in April before easing slightly to ₹7,442 in May
- Mumbai-Kuala Lumpur fares rose from ₹10,778 in March to ₹22,650 in April before remaining elevated at ₹21,069 in May
- Bengaluru-Singapore fares climbed from ₹12,417 in March to ₹19,914 in May
- Mumbai-Krabi fares increased from ₹15,186 in March to ₹21,500 in May

longer stays, premium experiences and international journeys.

Sequential increase was visible across several international sectors tracked by ixigo. A case in point was Mumbai-Kuala Lumpur fares, which rose from

₹10,778 in March to ₹22,650 in April before remaining elevated at ₹21,069 in May.

Data showed that New Delhi-Ho Chi Minh fares increased from ₹14,688 in March to ₹23,178 in April before easing marginally to ₹21,256 in May. Similarly,

Bengaluru-Singapore fares climbed from ₹12,417 in March to ₹19,914 in May, while Mumbai-Krabi fares increased from ₹15,186 in March to ₹21,500 in May. New Delhi-Phuket fares rose from ₹13,404 in March to ₹19,500 in May.

LONG-HAUL SECTORS
The trend in long-haul sectors also recorded elevated fare levels during the period, with fares between New Delhi and Paris increasing from ₹33,442 in March to ₹39,242 in April, while Mumbai-Singapore fares climbed from ₹15,680 in March to ₹22,617 in May.

Domestic fares remained comparatively moderate. Airfares on the Mumbai-New Delhi route increased from ₹6,530 in March to ₹7,526 in April before easing slightly to ₹7,442 in May.

Bengaluru-New Delhi fares rose from ₹7,931 in March to ₹8,969 in April and remained elevated at ₹8,799 in May.



STATE HONOUR. Prime Minister Narendra Modi being conferred the Grand Cross of the Royal Norwegian Order of Merit by King Harald V in Oslo on Monday ANI

roadmap spanning AI, critical minerals, innovation, trade and cultural exchanges.

During bilateral talks in Sweden on Sunday, Modi and Swedish Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson reviewed bilateral ties and discussed ways to strengthen cooperation in strategic, economic and emerging technology sectors. The strategic partnership would be guided by four pillars — strategic dialogue for stability and security, next-generation economic partnership, emerging technologies and trusted connectivity and cooperation in areas linked to planet, health and resilience.

India and Sweden also launched the India-Sweden Joint Innovation Partnership 2.0 that envisages a virtual joint science and technology centre and deeper collaboration in AI, 6G, quantum computing, critical minerals, renewable energy and smart grid technologies.

The two countries also endorsed the development of the India-Sweden Technology and AI Corridor, aimed at boosting cooperation in AI and digital transformation.

See demand for long products softening on slowing construction activity: Tata Steel CEO

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

After a strong demand season, Tata Steel expects marginal softness in offtake, especially in the long products used in the real-estate and infrastructure projects, while that of flat products remains strong.

TV Narendran, MD and CEO, Tata Steel, told *businessline* that the SME sector

is starting to feel a little bit of stress not just because of steel prices, but because all input costs have gone up for both steel producers and customers.

“In flat products, the demand is still quite strong because the auto industry is going strong, but do not know if the fuel price increases will have an impact going forward,” he said.

However, in long products, the construction

activity slowed down a little bit more because of people going back to their home States to vote, creating some labour shortages, he said.

“Long products may be feeling a little bit more of the demand pressure than flat. Otherwise, I think the demand is still quite okay,” he added.

STEEL PRICES
The company expects steel prices to remain strong on

the back of rise in raw material costs. Despite the price increases, Narendran said



the landed cost of steel imports are higher than domestic prices by over ₹2,000-

3,000 (a tonne) and, hence, imports are not such a big threat, yet. In the last three weeks, hot rolled coil prices in China and ex-China have gone up by about \$20-25 a tonne. Moreover, Iran used to export a lot of slabs and billets, and this has come to a halt after the war.

China has stepped into that space, bringing in better balance in international markets now than it was three months ago, he said. While

China still exports 9 million tonnes or more of steel per month, the pressure from China is a little less as they have also introduced licences for exports, said Narendran.

Steel prices for flat products went up in April and stabilised at a certain level. “We expect June quarter realisations will be about ₹6,000 a tonne higher than Q4 in India. And even in Europe, steel prices have

gone up quarter-on-quarter by about €80 and about £80 in the UK,” he said.

Similarly, the costs have also gone up due to rise in various input costs in India, the exchange rate and also the impact of West Asia war, he said. Not all price increases will translate into EBITDA profit, but overall, the margins should be better in the UK and India for Q1 compared to Q4, said Narendran.

FLAMINGO FIESTA



PINK PARTY. Flamingos are seen in large numbers at the NRI pond in Seawoods in Mumbai on Monday EMMANUEL YOGINI

Adani Enterprises settles US case on Iran sanctions violation for \$275 m

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Adani Enterprises has agreed to pay \$275 million to settle potential civil liability with the US Treasury Department's Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) over alleged violations of Iran-related sanctions linked to the import of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG).

According to an OFAC enforcement release, Adani Enterprises imported 35 cargoes of LPG between November 2023 and June 2025 from a Dubai-based trader that purportedly supplied the gas from Oman and Iraq, but which the OFAC said was actually sourced from Iran.

The US agency said 32 US dollar-denominated payments worth about \$192.1 million were processed through US financial institutions for the transactions.



REMEDIAL ACTIONS
The OFAC said the case was considered “egregious” and not voluntarily self-disclosed, though the final settlement amount reflected the company's cooperation and remedial actions after the conduct was discovered.

The agency alleged that Adani Enterprises overlooked several red flags indicating a possible Iranian origin of the cargoes, including suspicious shipping

activity, vessel tracking manipulation, inconsistencies in certificates of origin and unusually discounted pricing.

DUE DILIGENCE
The sanctions watchdog said Adani Enterprises failed to conduct enhanced due diligence despite repeated third-party concerns and questionable shipping patterns. The OFAC also noted that some payments were temporarily halted by banks because of internal sanctions concerns.

Following media reports in June 2025, Adani Enterprises suspended LPG imports and hired US-based legal counsel to conduct an internal investigation.

The OFAC said the company cooperated extensively, provided large volumes of documentation and implemented stronger sanctions compliance measures across the group.

This IIT-M lab is ‘eyeing’ support for dyslexic children

The Language and Cognition Lab uses eye-tracking tech to study language processing, understanding

Rohan Das
Chennai

For a child with dyslexia, the struggles are not just limited to reading and understanding words or comprehension; over time, their challenges are mistaken for poor academic ability, leading to a diminished sense of self-worth.

This is the experience of thousands of children who struggle with the learning disorder that is notoriously hard to diagnose and tackle in a conservative education system like India's.

IIT-Madras, an institute that has given India some of its finest technologists and most innovative start-ups, has now geared up to address this very challenge.

The Institute's Language and Cognition Lab, set up in November last year, aims to use eye-tracking techno-



LOOKING AT A BREAKTHROUGH. Anindita Sahoo (left) and her team demonstrating the eye-tracking technology

logy to study how language is processed. Anindita Sahoo, a faculty at the Department of Humanities and Social Sciences, heads the lab along with a team of 10 young researchers.

“The underlying idea is the eye-mind hypothesis. Using the device we track pupil movement, fixations and blinking patterns while a person reads to analyse how words are processed and understood. The harder the word is to process, the more time a per-

son fixates on it,” Sahoo explains.

READING PATTERNS
Building on this premise, the lab's first project will involve distinguishing between ‘typical’ and ‘atypical’ reading patterns. The plan is to collaborate with the Madras Dyslexia Association's special school, alongside a team of psychologists and special educators, to study how children with dyslexia read words and stories displayed on

screens. “Our hypothesis is that complex words with multiple morphemes like ‘re-educated’ or ‘deconstruction’ may be harder for atypical readers. This way we can pinpoint difficult words and sentences in a way traditional classroom observation cannot,” she says. Sahoo adds that the goal will be to eventually create a repository of difficult words, phrases, sentence structures and reading patterns associated with dyslexic readers.

She mentions that once these difficult words are identified, educators can simplify language, substitute difficult words with easier alternatives and redesign study material for dyslexic children.

The research is currently in its early stages and the expectation is to have the first version of the repository ready by the year-end.

OTHER LANGUAGES
While the team is undertaking this project using English language text, Sahoo and her aim to eventually apply it to multiple languages and also work on developing regional language diagnostic tools for dyslexia, a critical need to improve the diagnosis of the disorder in India.

The lab also has other ambitious long-term plans. Sahoo says if funding permits, it will look to combine the current eye-tracking technology with electroencephalogram to further expand the understanding of language processing. The team is also currently working on a standardised testing tool to assess non-native speakers in Indian languages, akin to tests like TOEFL and IELTS.



Hamilton, Chief Economist for American Petroleum Institute industry group.

Indian refiners' decision to cut alkylate exports could not have come at a worse time for California. Motorists are already paying the highest gasoline prices since 2022 amid the global fuel supply crisis caused by the war, and lower alkylate supply will likely inflate prices as the summer driving season boosts demand, said GasBuddy analyst Patrick DeHaan.

“The more acute the alkylate supply shortfall becomes, the higher it could push prices in California,” said De Haan. A spokesperson for the California Energy Commission, a state agency, said California is aware of India's evolving priorities, but has a healthy supply of gasoline and blending components. The CEC does not foresee a shortfall, but is monitoring the situation.

How Indian refiners cutting down on alkylate output is driving up fuel prices in California

Reuters
New York

In India, there is a shortage of cooking gas. In California, motorists are paying \$6 a gallon for gasoline. They are both symptoms of the worst-ever energy supply disruption.

They are also directly connected, and evidence of the knock-on effects across the global economy of the US-Israeli war with Iran.

Iran's near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz has thrown global oil trade into disarray, cutting off importers from around one-fifth of the global oil supply that traversed the waterway before the war. This has forced oil buyers to burn through stockpiles and take other emergency measures to manage global fuel shortages.

Some attempts to address the shortages, such as the India's effort to shore up lique-

fied petroleum gas supplies, are spreading the pain.

PRODUCTION SHIFT
India uses LPG as its primary cooking fuel. Cut off from West Asian LPG, which represented over 90 per cent of India's total imports of the fuel before the Iran war, New Delhi has directed refiners to maximise LPG output. To comply, refiners have cut production of alkylates — motor fuel additives made using LPG as feedstock.

For California, shrinking alkylate supply compounds concerns of a potential gasoline shortage due to declining fuel production and exports from Asian refiners struggling to access West Asian crude oil.

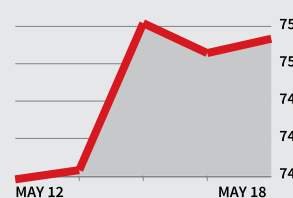
IN HIGH DEMAND
Alkylates are highly sought in California because they burn cleaner than other additives, and the state requires a unique gasoline blend to re-

duce smog. That is why California's motorists face a double whammy from the war: A slump in Asian fuel exports has directly hit its motor fuel supply chain, and additives needed for the state's unique gasoline blend are harder to procure because of India's conservation of cooking fuel.

“With India's LPG supply constrained by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, refiners there are producing and exporting less alkylate, adding pressure to an already tight California gasoline market,” said Mason

the hindu businessline

SENSEX 75315.04 (+77.05)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23649.95	+6.45
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.33	-0.03
US Dollar (in ₹)	96.34	+0.38
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	157107.00	-470
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	268040.00	-460

UPBEAT PROSPECTS.

Jayant Acharya, CEO, JSW Steel, says with JFE and Posco JVs, the company is bullish on growth despite Gulf war concerns p2



GAINING SPARKLE.

Silver to trade at a premium as govt curbs hit supplies; silver MFs, ETFs gain momentum p8

QUICKLY.

DESPITE US SANCTIONS
India to continue purchasing Russian crude



New Delhi: India will continue to buy Russian crude oil regardless of the status of the US sanctions waiver, based on commercial viability, after Washington let the waiver on Moscow's seaborne crude oil expire over the last weekend. It also reiterates India's position *vis-a-vis* its energy security, particularly at a time when crude oil and refined product prices are heading north, impacting the profits and margins of the PSU oil marketing companies. **p3**

NO CLARITY ON DATE
Delay over GST Council meet continues

New Delhi: The wait for the next GST Council meeting is getting longer, with no clarity yet on when it will be convened despite governments being formed in four States and one Union Territory. The last GST Council meeting was held on September 3, 2025. **p3**

New global test norms may raise car prices, lower mileage

DOUBLE HIT. Stricter WLTP vehicle testing, alongside CAFE III norms, planned from 2027

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Car buyers may soon face a double blow: Lower certified mileage or electric vehicle-range figures and higher vehicle prices, even when the vehicles remain mechanically unchanged.

From April 1, 2027, India plans to replace the current Modified Indian Driving Cycle (MIDC) with the tougher Worldwide Harmonised Light Vehicles Test Procedure (WLTP), while simultaneously tightening fuel-efficiency norms under CAFE III regulations.

Together, the changes could make many petrol, diesel and electric vehicles appear 10-20 per cent less efficient and force automakers to add new technologies to meet stricter emission targets.

A petrol car currently rated at 25 km/l could see its certified mileage fall to around 21-22 km/l under WLTP norms, while an EV claiming a 500-km range may be certified closer to 430-450 km.



PRICE HIKE AHEAD. Entry-level small cars may cost ₹30,000-50,000 more, while premium hatchbacks and compact SUVs could go up by ₹40,000-1 lakh

Industry experts say the vehicles themselves will not become less efficient; the new tests would simply better reflect real-world driving conditions.

TWIN CHALLENGE

“Depending on the vehicle and configuration, the reduction in certified fuel-economy numbers can often be in the range of 10-20 per cent,” said Amit Bhatt, India Managing Director at the International Council on Clean Transportation (ICCT).

The simultaneous rollout of CAFE III and WLTP creates a two-layer challenge for automakers.

While CAFE III tightens fleet-average carbon dioxide targets, WLTP changes the methodology for calculating emissions by incorporating higher speeds, stronger acceleration and more realistic operating conditions.

Industry executives and analysts estimate compliance costs could rise sharply across segments.

Entry-level small cars may

require upgraded engine-management software, fuel injectors and sensors, adding ₹30,000-50,000 per vehicle.

Premium hatchbacks and compact SUVs may need gasoline particulate filters, catalytic converters, mild-hybrid systems and aerodynamic improvements, pushing up costs by ₹40,000 to ₹1 lakh.

Larger SUVs and MPVs are expected to face the steepest increase, adding ₹1.2 lakh to ₹2 lakh per vehicle.

Randheer Singh, a mobility and energy-transition expert, said WLTP effectively raises the compliance burden under CAFE III because certified fuel-efficiency figures become lower and measured emissions higher.

TRANSITION READY

Global luxury carmakers such as Mercedes-Benz, BMW and Audi may adapt faster because many of their models are already WLTP-certified overseas.

Domestic manufacturers including Maruti Suzuki, Tata Motors and Mahindra & Mahindra are already recalibrating vehicles and validating compliance strategies.

PSBs, financial institutions, insurance cos to implement austerity measures

Our Bureau
New Delhi

● VIRTUAL MODE

Under the new measures, all meetings, reviews and consultations must be conducted via video conferencing unless physical presence is deemed essential

The Financial Services Department on Monday instructed public sector banks, insurance companies, financial institutions and regional rural banks to implement cost-cutting measures.

“Austerity measures are being implemented to rationalise expenditure, keeping in mind the West Asia crisis,” said a senior official while confirming the issuance of the circular dated May 18.

Under the new measures, all meetings, reviews and consultations must be conducted via video conferencing unless physical presence is deemed essential, said the circular, seen by *businessline*.

FOREIGN TRAVEL CURB

Foreign travel by top executives of the organisations, including Chairpersons, Managing Directors and Chief Executive Officers, should be kept below prescribed limits, with overseas engagements to be attended virtually wherever possible, it said.

Separately, the government asked the organisations to accelerate adoption of electric vehicles. “All or-

work from home for up to two days per week.

“Effort would be to ensure at least half of the staff are available in the office,” said the order. Further, those working from home must be available on phone and be ready to attend office as and when required.

SC VIDEO HEARING

Keeping this office memorandum in mind, the Supreme Court has implemented some measures.

Accordingly, matters listed on miscellaneous days (Mondays, Fridays or such other days as declared to be miscellaneous) and those listed during the court's partial working days will only be heard by video-conferencing.

Also, to ensure optimum utilisation of fuel, Supreme Court judges have unanimously resolved to encourage car-pooling arrangements among themselves.

At the same time, till further orders, up to 50 per cent of staff in each branch/section of the registry are permitted to work from home for up to two days per week, provided the remaining staff remain available in office to ensure uninterrupted functioning, said a circular by the top court.

Bars, coins made up 41% of gold demand in Jan-March

Rohan Das
Chennai

India's appetite for gold is well-known, but recent data show a sharp rise in the demand for the precious metal in the form of bars and coins, underscoring its growing appeal as an investment asset.

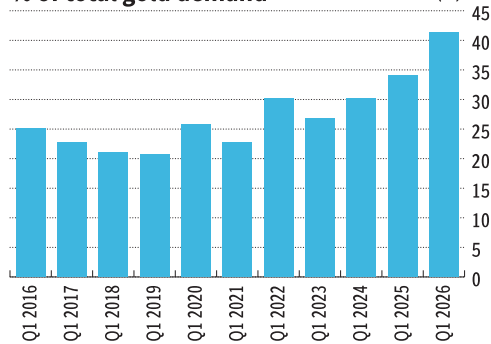
World Gold Council (WGC) data show that bar and coin demand stood at 62.3 tonnes in the quarter ended March 2026 (Q1 CY26), accounting for about 41 per cent of India's total gold offtake during the period.

This was significantly higher than gold ETF demand of 19.9 tonnes in the same quarter. The share of bars and coins in the overall gold demand has risen from 34 per cent in the same quarter last year, well above their typical 20-30 per cent range over the past decade. In value terms, bar and coin demand surged 129 per cent



Rising share

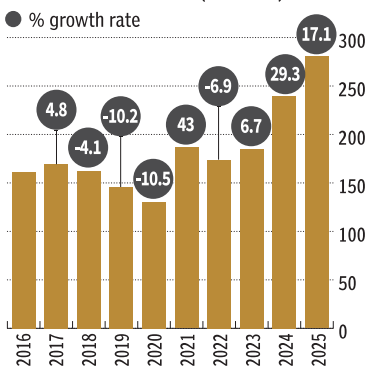
Demand for gold bars and coins as % of total gold demand



Source: World Gold Council

Strong growth

■ Bar and coin demand (in tonnes)
● % growth rate



to \$10 billion in Q1 CY26 from \$4 billion in Q1 CY25.

The WGC defines demand as the gold acquired by final end-users in the country.

Kavitha Chacko, Research

Head, WGC, said the trend signals a structural shift, with gold increasingly being viewed as an investment vehicle.

“This shift is reflected in

the demand mix: Investment demand accounted for nearly 70 per cent of total gold demand in Q1, while jewellery's share fell to around 30 per cent — the

lowest level since 2000,” she said.

Elevated gold prices, particularly early in the quarter when gold outperformed other domestic assets, drove investment-led buying in bars and coins, Chacko added. Preference for coins and bars is also supported by the fact that, unlike ETFs, they can eventually be converted into jewellery.

Jateen N Trivedi, Vice-President, Commodity and Currency Research at LKP Securities, said the sharp rise in gold prices over the past year, coupled with a challenging equity market, had boosted investor interest in gold. “People want to buy gold but, unlike jewellery, which often comes in larger denominations, bars and coins can be bought in small ticket sizes of ₹5,000-10,000. Moreover, there is minimal loss in terms of making charges,” he said.

With inputs from intern Anu Keerthana

CONGRESS' COMEBACK



POWER SHIFT. Newly sworn-in Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan (right) and Congress leader and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi interact with an elderly woman after the swearing-in ceremony of the State government in Thiruvananthapuram on Monday. Ending a decade-long hiatus, the Congress-led United Democratic Front returned to power in Kerala, with the 61-year-old Satheesan sworn in as the State's 13th Chief Minister at a packed ceremony at the Central Stadium **(Report on p9)** **PTI**

India develops world's first AI gene editor for crops

Tool can tweak a plant's DNA to develop traits such as higher yield, disease resistance

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

In a breakthrough that could redefine crop biotechnology, scientists at the Indian Council of Agricultural Research's ICAR-Central Rice Research Institute have developed and experimentally validated the world's first AI-designed genome-editing tool for plants.

This marks a major advance beyond the existing CRISPR (clustered regularly interspaced short palindromic repeats) gene editing technology that depends on naturally occurring microbial proteins.

Why is gene-editing significant? It offers unprecedented potential to tweak a plant's DNA to develop traits such as higher yield, climate resilience, disease



resistance and improved nutrition — without introducing foreign genes. In theory, grains can be re-engineered to lower starch/sugar content, boost protein levels and more.

Until now, gene-editing tools relied on proteins borrowed from bacteria and other microbes found in nature.

The Indian team's breakthrough lies in showing that

artificial intelligence can design entirely new enzymes from scratch that work efficiently inside plants.

This could open the door to tailor-made editing systems that can be cheaper, more versatile and less constrained by global CRISPR patents.

Led by scientist Kutubuddin Ali Molla, the team showed that AI-designed enzymes can accurately edit plant DNA, enabling gene knockout, base editing and prime editing in crops.

While a US company had earlier developed a similar AI-designed system for human cells, this is the first successful demonstration in plants.

Speaking to *businessline*, which got to know about the new product from BioRxiv pre-print server,

Molla said, “The platform may open new avenues for building customised genome-editing systems for agriculture and could also help address some intellectual property limitations associated with existing CRISPR technologies.”

RICE AS A MODEL

The new platform, named Plant-OpenCRISPR1 (POC1), builds on OpenCRISPR-1 (OC1), an AI-generated nuclease developed for human cells.

“We have developed and validated a suite of OC1-based genome-editing tools for plants, taking rice as a model, demonstrating the versatility of AI-designed nuclease in plant systems,” Molla said. He said this tool could have major implications for biotechnology and food security.

TVS Venu Group to acquire 9.9% stake in Jana Small Finance Bank for ₹193 crore

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

The TVS Venu Group has acquired a 9.9 per cent stake in Jana Small Finance Bank for ₹193.3 crore as part of a broader investment to deepen its presence in the financial services sector, the company said on Monday.

The acquisition will be made through a mix of primary warrant subscription and secondary share purchase, including a 4.9 per cent stake to be held directly by TVS Motor Company.

The TVS Group, which already operates in the lending business through TVS Credit Services and Home Credit India, has signed definitive agreements to acquire a 100 per cent stake in PGIM India Asset Management.

The Investment Commit-

tee of TVS Motor approved the purchase of 51.6 lakh equity shares from Jana Holdings through a share purchase agreement, according to an exchange filing.

The transaction is expected to close within three months, subject to customary conditions.

DIGITAL ECOSYSTEM

The move marks the latest expansion of the TVS Group's financial services ambitions, following its agreement to acquire 100 per cent stake in PGIM India Asset Management.

“We firmly believe that a key driver to India's growth is the strengthening and expansion of India's financial services,” said Sudarshan Venu.

He added that the investment aligns with the Group's long-term strategy of backing institutions serving In-

This is TVS Group's latest expansion in financial services after its acquisition of PGIM India Asset Management

dia's growing digital financial ecosystem.

\$6.5 BILLION REVENUE

The TVS Venu Group comprises TVS Motor, TVS Credit, TVS Emerald and other entities, including promoter entities, with revenue of around \$6.5 billion in FY26.

The Group operates as an institutional platform focused on building, anchoring and scaling globally respected enterprises across mobility, financial services, real-

estate and lifestyle sectors. With a presence in over 90 countries, the Group employs more than 64,000 people representing over 50 nationalities and has centres of excellence across India, Indonesia, Italy and the UK.

JANA PERFORMANCE

Founded in 2006, Jana Small Finance Bank is among the country's largest small finance banks by assets and deposits.

The bank reported a total income of ₹6,374.8 crore and a profit after tax of ₹326.4 crore in FY26.

It serves over 12 million customers through 822 outlets across 23 States and two Union Territories, with advances and deposits exceeding ₹35,000 crore each as of March 31.

Jana Small Finance shares were down 5.46 per cent at ₹462.35 on the BSE.

QUICKLY.

Cognizant doubles stock buyback target to \$2 b



Chennai: Cognizant has announced that it has authorised an increase of \$2 billion to its existing share repurchase programme, taking the company's total share repurchase authorisation now stands at \$3.45 billion. Cognizant has also doubled its share repurchase target for 2026 to \$2 billion, an increase of \$1 billion over its prior expectation. The additional \$1 billion in share repurchases is expected to be completed during Q2 of CY 2026. **OUR BUREAU**

Amazon Now to deploy 1,000 Eicher e-trucks

Mumbai: Amazon India on Monday said it plans to deploy around 1,000 Volvo Eicher electric trucks to support its quick commerce service Amazon Now's operations by 2028 with 50 of them already in operations. In daily operations, these trucks are expected to cover 100-180 km and support multiple trips between facilities, with a fast-charging time of around 50 minutes, it said. **PM**

Strides Pharma Q4 profit jumps 51% at ₹129 crore

New Delhi: Strides Pharma Science Ltd on Monday reported a 51 per cent rise in consolidated net profit at ₹129.28 crore for the fourth quarter ended March 31, 2026 driven by a good growth in its main markets excluding the US. The company had posted a profit of ₹85.62 crore for the year-ago period, Strides Pharma said in a regulatory filing. **PTI**

ZyduS Wellness faces execution test with ₹7,800 crore acquisition bet

POWER-PACKED. Eyes ₹5,700 crore in revenue as Comfort Click, RiteBite Max Protein, Complan drive growth

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

ZyduS Wellness Ltd, which reported consolidated net sales of ₹3,940 crore in FY26, up 46.4 per cent from ₹2,691 crore in FY25, EBITDA of ₹510 crore, up 34.2 per cent from ₹380 crore, and profit after tax of ₹197 crore, is entering what could be the most consequential phase in its transformation as it looks to convert nearly ₹7,800 crore spent on acquisitions into faster growth, stronger margins and lower debt.

Brokerage estimates place FY27 revenue at around ₹5,700 crore, implying growth of about 44.7 per cent over FY26, while EBITDA margins are expected to improve to 14.5-15.5 per cent from 12.9 per cent in FY26.

Company management has said that it aims to lift EBITDA margins to 17-18 per cent over the next few years, excluding Comfort Click.

“We have used all the levers for growth, organically through innovation, and inorganically, through acquisitions

TARUN ARORA
CEO & Whole Time Director



The company's investor presentation shows revenue has compounded at 18.5 per cent annually since FY22, while gross margin expanded to 60.2 per cent in FY26 from 52.5 per cent in FY25, helped by a richer product mix and the addition of higher-margin businesses.

MONETISATION

Over the past seven years, ZyduS Wellness has transformed itself from a niche wellness company built around Sugar Free, Nutralite and Everyuth into a broader health and nutrition plat-

form spanning Glucon-D, Nycil, Complan, RiteBite Max Protein and UK-based vitamins business Comfort Click.

The shift was driven by three major acquisitions: Kraft Heinz India's consumer business for ₹4,600 crore, RiteBite Max Protein for ₹390 crore and Comfort Click for ₹2,800 crore.

“We have used all the levers for growth, organically through innovation, distribution expansion and brand building, and inorganically through acquisitions and international expan-

sion,” CEO & Whole Time Director, Tarun Arora told *businessline* in an exclusive interaction.

Arora said the company has expanded into markets across West Asia, Africa and Southeast Asia, using international operations both as growth engines and as testing grounds for new products before launching them in India.

ENGINES OF GROWTH

Sugar Free continues to dominate the sugar substitute market with a 96.1 per cent share, while Sugar Free Green has delivered 20 consecutive quarters of double-digit growth and now accounts for more than a quarter of the brand's business.

Glucon-D, with a 58.9 per cent share in a ₹1,035-crore category, has expanded into performance hydration through Glucon-D Recharge, while Nutralite has broadened from spreads into mayonnaise, peanut butter, ghee, butter and cheese.

RiteBite Max Protein, acquired when revenues were about ₹130 crore, has emerged as one of the company's strongest performers. The company's distribution mix is also changing rapidly. Organised channels accounted for 30 per cent of domestic sales in FY26, up from 13 per cent in FY21, including 17 per cent from e-commerce, while quick commerce now contributes 7-8 per cent of domestic revenue.

COMFORT CLICK

Comfort Click, a digital-first vitamins and supplements platform, generated over ₹1,500 crore in annual revenue with 5-year revenue CAGR of about 57 per cent.

Complan held a 4 per cent market share in Q4 FY26 but delivered near double-digit growth. ZyduS is repositioning the brand through Complan NutriGro for toddlers and VieMax for adult nutrition. “Complan has to be reimagined for the consumers of today,” Arora said.

Maruti Suzuki adds 2.5 lakh units to annual capacity with second factory at Kharkhoda

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Maruti Suzuki India Ltd (MSIL) on Monday said it has commenced commercial production at the second plant of its Kharkhoda manufacturing facility in Haryana that will add production capacity of another 2.5 lakh units per annum to its total capacity.

“This second plant has an annual production capacity of 2.5 lakh units, taking the total capacity at Kharkhoda to five lakh units,” said MSIL.

Maruti Suzuki's overall annual production capacity across its facilities in Gurugram, Manesar and Kharkhoda in Haryana, and Hansalpur in Gujarat is now 26.5 lakh units, the company added.

ONE OF THE BIGGEST

Once fully operational, the Kharkhoda facility will be among Suzuki's largest four-wheeler manufacturing locations with capacity to produce one million vehicles per annum, it said.

It currently manufactures the compact SUV Brezza and

mid-SUV Victoris at the facility. The foundation stone of the Kharkhoda facility was laid by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in August 2022.

BACKGROUND

Recently, at its annual results, MSIL had said that it will invest ₹14,000 crore in FY27 to add five lakh more capacity in two plants — one each in Kharkhoda (Haryana) and Hansalpur (Gujarat) — from the current capacity of 24 lakh units per annum.

In January this year, MSIL Board approved the purchase of land in Khoraj Industrial Estate, Sanand, Gujarat for its fifth manufacturing facility and announced ₹4,950 crore for land acquisition and preparation.

In March, the Board also approved an additional ₹10,189 crore for phase-I development with 2.5 lakh unit capacity and development of common infrastructure and facilities.

RC Bhargava, Chairman, MSIL, said that the growth is now more or less determined by the company's ability to add capacity and to run.

Vodafone Idea sees subscriber stabilisation, profit boost amid restructuring in AGR liability

Our Bureau
Mumbai

A decisive quarter of network rollouts, rising data usage and a restructured AGR settlement have stabilised subscribers and materially improved Vodafone Idea's balance sheet, setting the stage for a multi-year capex push and margin recovery, said the management of the telecom operator in an earnings call.

The company is looking to sustain the upward mo-

mentum in ARPU through higher data usage, upgrading feature phone base and migration to unlimited plans.

The aim is also to lift cash EBITDA margin to the mid-30s from the current mid-20s over the medium term if revenue and efficiency targets are met.

BALANCE SHEET

The appointment of Kumar Mangalam Birla as the non-executive chairman of its board and the infusion of ₹4,730 crore as capital by the Aditya Birla group “reaffirm

the strong and continued commitment of the promoter group to our long-term growth,” said CEO Abijit Kishore.

The reduction in AGR liability “meaningfully improves our balance sheet and provides a definitive conclusion to the AGR matter,” he said.

Its AGR dues have been finalised at ₹64,046 crore as of December 31, 2025, a reduction from the earlier frozen figure of ₹87,695 crore.

“The revised liability and structured instalments pro-



duced a one-time accounting benefit that materially improved reported profits for the year,” he said.

The company reported stabilised subscribers at about 192.8 million, with sequential improvement in February and March — the first sustained uptick since the merger.

TURNAROUND STEPS

Kishore credited targeted 4G/5G investments and product differentiation for the turnaround, noting that “we are focusing on quality of customer acquisition rather than quantity — that is one of the reasons gross additions were reduced by

GNFC Q4 PAT jumps 88% to ₹396 cr on lower input costs, better realisations

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad



State-run Gujarat Narmada Valley Fertilizers & Chemicals Ltd (GNFC) reported an 88 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) jump in consolidated profit after tax (PAT) to ₹396 crore for the quarter ended March 2026, aided by improved product realisations, lower input costs and one-time income in the fertilizer segment.

Revenue from operations rose 7.4 per cent to ₹2,208 crore during the quarter. The sharp rise in profitability came despite relatively moderate revenue growth, reflecting a strong improvement in operating margins during the quarter. The com-

pany said earnings were boosted by better sales realisations across a majority of products, along with lower raw material and energy-linked input costs.

The chemicals segment, particularly, benefited from higher realisations, improved volumes and higher other income, while losses in the fertilizer segment narrowed due to lower fixed

costs and one-time income booked during the quarter.

“The result has improved mainly due to better sales realisation and lower input costs,” Managing Director Rajkumar Beniwal said. GNFC, a joint sector enterprise promoted by the Gujarat Government and Gujarat State Fertilizers & Chemicals Ltd (GSFC), operates integrated fertilizer and chemical manufacturing facilities at Bharuch in Gujarat.

Revenue from the fertilizer segment rose 1.6 per cent y-o-y in Q4, supported by higher volumes, although realisations remained under pressure. The chemicals segment continued to outperform, with revenues rising 9.1 per cent.

Pearl Global plans to infuse ₹200-250 cr in FY27

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Apparel exporter Pearl Global Industries plans to invest another ₹200-250 crore in the current financial year as it looks to scale capacity, deepen its global manufacturing footprint, and stay on track to become a ₹6,000-crore company by 2028, Pallab Banerjee, Managing Director, told *businessline*.

The company, which recently crossed ₹5,000 crore in annual revenue, said the investments will be directed towards infrastructure creation and capacity expansion across markets.

“Last year, we committed ₹250 crore and those projects are currently under progress. This year again, we have committed ₹200-250 crore towards growth and in-

frastructure building,” Banerjee said.

Pearl Global, which manufactures apparel across India, Bangladesh, Vietnam, Indonesia and Guatemala, currently has an installed capacity of over 100 million pieces, including partner factories. Of this, India accounts for nearly 26 million pieces, while Bangladesh remains its largest base at about 59 million pieces.

The company is a manufacturing partner for global brands such as Gap, Zara, Tommy Hilfiger and Calvin Klein.

Banerjee noted that the company has built a diversified manufacturing and market presence to cushion itself against geopolitical and trade-related disruptions.

“If an opportunity comes for 20-30 per cent growth, definitely we are ready for



Pallab Banerjee, MD, Pearl Global Industries

it,” he said, adding that Pearl has the ability to scale production quickly depending on order flows.

ON GROWTH PATH

The company continues to target annual growth of 12-14 per cent, although FY25

growth was significantly higher at nearly 30 per cent. It also indicated that demand from global retailers has remained resilient despite geopolitical tensions and rising raw material costs.

“We have not seen any slowdown in the US in terms of consumer behaviour. The buying pattern remains stable, the demand is stable,” Banerjee said.

EXPANDING FOOTPRINT

According to the company, global brands are increasingly favouring suppliers with multi-country manufacturing capabilities following disruptions caused by the pandemic and geopolitical conflicts.

Retailers are also seeking faster replenishment cycles and greater focus on sustainable sourcing practices from international vendors.

Sanjay Dutt's TIGERFIRE Vodka eyes 25,000 sales in India by year-end

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

TIGERFIRE Vodka, the premium spirits brand co-founded by actor Sanjay Dutt along with Paresh Ghelani, is betting big on India's growing premium vodka segment, with plans to expand to five Indian markets within a year and double that presence over the next two years.

Speaking about the brand's growth strategy, Paresh Ghelani, Co-Founder, TIGERFIRE Vodka, said the company expects to sell 30,000-40,000 cases globally by the end of this year, including 20,000-25,000 cases in India alone, as it accelerates both domestic and international expansion.

Launched in India in December 2025, TIGERFIRE is a super-premium artisan-crafted vodka manufactured and bottled in France.

Ghelani said, “We always had a global vision in mind. Our first release was in Los Angeles, and then we did our grand launch in India.”

The company is currently present across Maharashtra, Goa and Haryana, while registrations are underway for Telangana, Delhi, and Punjab.

INDIA PRESENCE

Globally, TIGERFIRE has already established a presence in the United States through premium retail outlets, curated hospitality channels and high-end restaurants.

“We're selecting high-end restaurants across different regions in America for now, and then we'll expand as we go,” Ghelani said.

Ghelani said the company sees a significant opportunity in India despite the country traditionally being whiskey-dominated. “India is a large whiskey-drinking country, but vodka is one of the few spirit categories that is growing here,” he said. “

JSW Steel, along with JVs, eyes 80 mt capacity by 2030, says Joint MD & CEO

bl.interview

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Aided by a rally in prices and low-cost inventory, JSW Steel has posted much better profits in the March quarter. With joint ventures with the world's two largest steel companies JFE and POSCO, JSW Steel is bullish on future growth, though near-term prospects appear hazy due to the West Asia war. Jayant Acharya, Joint MD & CEO, JSW Steel, on the way forward.

Edited excerpts:

What drove better Q4

businessline.

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performance?

The main drivers are strong operational performance on the back of better volumes. We were able to increase our domestic sales and liquidate inventories.

We improved value-added and premium and special product mix, which has grown sharply.

In spite of the BF3 (blast furnace) shutdown, we were able to do a 96 per cent capacity utilisation through better plant reliability.

In the last two years, we worked on various digitalisation efforts and placed sensors on various parts of the plant for preventive maintenance.

Has the rise in steel prices also helped?

Yes. However, steel prices in Q3 were one of the lowest and touched a six-year low in December.

Later, the safeguard and seasonal domestic demand picked up.

This resulted in price increase, gradually, between January and April.

Internationally also prices have improved. Prices in Europe were at \$830 a tonne and \$1,100/tonne in the US.

It was about \$620 in India. Indian domestic prices are where it was three years back.

How do you view steel prices going ahead?

The prices will be range bound. We need to watch how the geopolitical situation plays out.

The IMF has said that the world has been very resilient and has given positive forecast, unless the war gets prolonged. We feel India is much better placed for good growth.

Do you see raw material prices going up further with the war in West Asia?

Coking coal prices last quarter went up by \$16/tonne. We will see another increase in this quarter — \$12-\$15.

The impact of higher cost of limestone and fluxes, plus the foreign exchange, will

“We will expand BPSL capacity to 10 mt from 4.5 mt. We should start the construction once the joint venture board takes a decision by next year

JAYANT ACHARYA
Joint MD & CEO, JSW Steel

certainly increase cost in June quarter.

How do you rate FY26 for JSW Steel?

We delivered strong operational numbers because of the domestic market and better asset utilisation. We have also concluded our joint ventures with JFE and POSCO.

The company, along with JVs and US operations, is targeting 80 million tonne (mt) capacity by 2030.

We have ramped up operations at our JVML (JSW Vijayanagar Metallics: 5 mtpa),



started the Utkal phase, and have worked on expansion in Kharagpur.

We are adding coking coal and iron ore mines in the domestic market. We have completed the acquisition of high-grade coking coal in Mozambique. It will enhance raw material security further.

What would be the investment for reaching 80 mtpa by 2030?

The board has already approved an investment of ₹1,26,000 crore. Additionally, we will be spending over

₹200,000 crore, at about ₹25,000 crore to ₹30,000 crore a year.

What are your fund raising plans?

We take enabling provisions to raise debt every year. However, our next phase of capex will mostly be funded through internal accruals.

The second tranche of JFE joint venture amount will be used to further deleverage the existing debt of ₹54,000 crore as of March-end.

We expect better cash flows in this year with better volumes.

This will also support capex spend.

We will be more comfortable with net debt to EBITDA of below 2.5 times against the current level of 3.

Will the West Asia war slow down private capex revival?

Private capex has started flowing. The automotive industry has announced close to ₹80,000 crore of investment.

Of course, people are con-

scious about the West risk and they will assess the risk.

When will the JV with JFE and POSCO take shape?

We are targeting 6 mt integrated greenfield steel plant with POSCO in Odisha. We expect to start the project sometime next year and complete it by 2031.

POSCO would certainly bring in technology for automotive grade steel, which will attract Korean customers. Imports from Korea will probably slow down.

Currently, POSCO is importing steel for its cold rolling plant in Maharashtra. The JV company will supply the steel once it becomes operational.

We will expand BPSL capacity to 10 mt from 4.5 mt. We should start the construction once the joint venture board takes a decision by next year.

It will be an expansion of 5.5 mt in one go. We are putting the plans together for technology, equipments and product mix.

QUICKLY.

Reserve Bank elevates
Gunveer Singh as ED

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank on Monday promoted Gunveer Singh as Executive Director (ED), the central bank said in a statement. Prior to this, Singh was serving as Chief General Manager-in-Charge of Department of Payment and Settlement Systems of the central bank. His appointment as ED is effective from Monday. As Executive Director, Singh will look after the Department of Payment and Settlement Systems, the RBI said. [PTI](#)

Industry meet in Bangkok
to address logistics issues

Mumbai: Industry leaders from the last-mile logistics, supply chain and commerce sectors will gather in Bangkok for two-days starting May 21 to discuss emerging challenges and the evolving needs of the last-mile logistics ecosystem. The 2026 APAC edition is expected to bring together senior executives from retail, logistics, FMCG and commerce sectors across the region. [OUR BUREAU](#)

NTPC's total installed
capacity surpasses 90 GW



New Delhi: The NTPC Group said on Monday that it has crossed 90 GW of installed power generation capacity. The milestone was achieved following the successful completion of trial operations of Unit 2 (800 megawatt) of Patratu Vidyut Utpadan Nigam (PVUNL), a subsidiary project comprising 3x800 MW units. This achievement marks another important step towards building a sustainable and energy-secure future for India. [OUR BUREAU](#)

India to continue purchasing Russian crude, notwithstanding US sanctions

ENERGY SECURITY. There is no shortage of crude, says Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary at the Oil Ministry

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

India will continue to buy Russian crude oil regardless of the status of the US sanctions waiver, based on commercial viability, after Washington let the waiver on Moscow's seaborne crude oil expire over the last weekend. Asked about India's position on the expiration of the US sanctions waiver, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary at the Oil Ministry, said, "Regarding the American waiver on Russia, I would like to emphasise that we have been purchasing from Russia earlier... I mean before the waiver also, during the waiver also, and now also."

REITERATING POSITION The statement also reiterates India's position *vis-a-vis* its energy security, particularly at a time when crude oil and refined product prices are hitting north adversely impacting the profits and margins of the PSU oil marketing companies (OMCs). "It is basically the commercial sense which should be there for us to purchase.



OIL STRATEGY. Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas

There is no shortage of crude. Enough crude has been tied up repeatedly... and this, whatever waiver or no waiver, it (availability) will not affect," Sharma emphasised. Kpler noted that even with the waiver uncertainty, it remains difficult to see India materially stepping back from Russian barrels. The issue is no longer purely about sanctions optics, but increasingly about supply security and economics in a much more fragile global crude system. "With continued geopolitical uncertainty and the Strait of Hormuz (SoH) situ-

ation still far from normal, including restricted transits, higher freight risk, and slower flows, Middle Eastern barrels are no longer as straightforward or secure as they were previously. In that environment, Russian crude continues to offer a clear advantage through both pricing and relatively stable logistics via non-Strait routes," emphasised the global real time data and analytics provider. Sumit Ritolia, Kpler's Sumit Ritolia, Kpler's Analyst for Refining & Modeling, explained that even if the waiver lapses, flows are likely to remain broadly stable, although they could ease mod-

estly from March levels. A key distinction often missed is that Russian oil itself is not sanctioned but certain entities, vessels, and financial channels are. Russia will continue to be a core supplier for India, but procurement must strictly ensure no involvement of sanctioned sellers or intermediaries, use of non-sanctioned vessels, fully compliant financial, insurance, and trading channels, he added. Refiners have remained more aggressive buyers of Russian and opportunistic Atlantic Basin barrels, along with bypassed flow of Saudi and UAE grades where available. Venezuelan crude has also made a notable return to India in recent months, partially offsetting the decline in Gulf-linked supply, Ritolia added. Sharma said the May 15 hike in retail prices of diesel, petrol and compressed natural gas (CNG) has helped the OMCs cut their losses. Earlier, the OMCs were faced with a loss of ₹1,000 crore per day, which post the price rise has come down to ₹750 crore a day. She added that a bailout package to make up for OMC losses for selling petrol, diesel, CNG and LPG below cost, is "still not on the table". Prashant Vasisht, Senior VP and Co-Group Head Corporate Ratings at ICRA, said the modest hike in retail price of ₹3 a litre for petrol and diesel provides limited relief to OMCs. The shift has not been a direct replacement of West Asian barrels from a single source, but rather a broader re-optimisation of the crude slate based on availability, re-

THE BACKBONE "Russian crude has remained the backbone of India's import slate, with flows recovering back toward around 1.9-2 million barrels per day (mb/d) in March (2026) after easing earlier in the year. May import is around 1.9 mb/d till date with overall expected to be around 1.8-1.9 mb/d," Ritolia said. India's procurement of almost 2 mb/d of crude oil from Russia is the highest since June 2025. The shift has not been a direct replacement of West Asian barrels from a single source, but rather a broader re-optimisation of the crude slate based on availability, re-

Commercial oil stocks are depleting rapidly: IEA chief

Reuters
Paris



Fatih Birol

Fatih Birol, head of the International Energy Agency, said on Monday that commercial oil inventories were depleting rapidly with only a few weeks worth left due to the Iran war and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz to shipping. Birol, who is participating in the Group of Seven finance leaders meeting in Paris, told reporters that the release of strategic oil reserves had added 2.5 million barrels of oil per day to the market, but said these reserves "are not endless". The onset of the spring planting and summer travel seasons in the northern hemisphere will drain inventories more quickly as demand for diesel, fertilizer, jet fuel and gasoline increases, Birol added. Asked about his comments in the G7 meeting, he said he described "a perception gap in the markets between the physical markets and the financial markets" for oil. Birol said that before the US and Israel launched attacks on Iran at the end of February, there was a major surplus in the oil markets, and commercial inventories were very high. But the situ-

ation has rapidly shifted due to the war. He said commercial inventories would last "several weeks, but we should be aware of the fact that it is declining rapidly". Global observed oil inventories fell at a record pace in March and April, dropping by 246 million barrels, the IEA said in its latest monthly oil market report. The 32-member IEA coordinated the largest-ever release of stocks from strategic reserves in March, agreeing to withdraw 400 million barrels to calm markets. Around 164 million barrels had been released by May 8, it said. Overall global oil supply will fall by around 3.9 million barrels per day across 2026 due to the war, the agency said, slashing its previous forecast, which had projected a 1.5 million bpd drop.

Industry must aim for import substitution, gear up for \$1 trillion export target: Goyal

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal has asked the industry to work with the government to identify goods that can be manufactured in India to bring down reliance on imports. Achieving the target of \$1 trillion exports of goods & services this year and \$2 trillion over the next five years would be the true hallmark

of an *Aatmanirbhar Bharat*, Goyal said addressing the website launch ceremony of *Bharatiya Vyapar Mahotsav* in New Delhi on Monday.

GROWING EXPORTS Exports of goods and services from India have reached \$863 billion in FY26, nearly 5 per cent higher than the previous year, despite global challenges, the Minister noted. Goyal said the industry must look at the import data regularly put up by



ON TARGET. Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal at the launch of Bharat Vyapar Mahotsav's official website in New Delhi [ANI](#)

the Commerce Department on its trade portal to identify

opportunities for local manufacture and substitution of

imports. "You should keep an eye on what goods are being imported, you will see opportunities in that too, what things can be manufactured in India." **DOMESTIC DRIVE** Giving an example, the Minister pointed out India still depended heavily on foreign countries in sectors such as capital goods. He called upon industrial clusters, including Rajkot, Jalandhar, Ludhiana, Batala

and Pune to increase domestic production instead of relying on imports. **MEDICAL DEVICES** The Minister also highlighted the growing domestic manufacturing of medical devices and referred to a CT scan machine manufactured in Visakhapatnam, as examples of sophisticated items now being manufactured in the country. "Greater adoption of Indian-made products would in-

crease demand and expand the scale of operations," he said. Goyal stressed on the need to promote domestic products and strengthen the spirit of *swadeshi*, noting that even small preferences for foreign goods can weaken domestic industry. As consumption grows with the expansion of the middle class, it is essential for India to meet its own requirements, otherwise imports will fill the gap, he said.

As wait for next GST Council meeting continues, experts flag disruptions in reforms momentum

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The wait for the next GST Council meeting is getting longer as even after the formation of governments in 4 States and 1 UT (with legislature), there is no clarity about when it would be scheduled.

The last GST Council meeting took place on September 3, 2025. Experts say prolonged gaps in GST Council meetings create business uncertainty and defer vital structural reforms. Even the last Council meeting took place almost after nine months. According to the Rules for Procedure and Conduct of Business Regulations of the GST Council, it is mandated to meet at least once every quarter of the financial year. The rules also stipulate that a notice for the meeting must be dispatched at least seven days prior to the scheduled date, though an emergency meeting can be convened with two days' notice. Typically, however, a 21-day notice period is observed. Last meeting of council unveiled GST2.0 with rate rationalisation and measures to ease compliance including registration within 3 working days and grant of 90 per



CRUCIAL MEETING. A file photo of Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman addressing the media regarding the 56th GST Council meeting in New Delhi in September 2025 [PTI](#)

cent provisional refunds arising out of Inverted Duty structure. However, expert says post implementation of these measures, some new issues have cropped up. "While the recent GST 2.0 rate rationalisation simplified tax slabs, it inadvertently accentuated inverted duty structures across key sectors like manufacturing, pharmaceuticals, and FMCG," said Saurabh Agarwal, Tax Partner at EY India. Further, because the current refund formula excludes input services, businesses face severe working capital blockages due to accumulated, unutilised credits—an unnecessary burden amplified by rising geopolitical fuel pressures. "Interim reliefs in Budget 2026, such as expedited provisional refunds, are welcome, but the industry urgently requires a comprehensive legislative correction to eliminate these em-

bedded tax costs. Additionally, allowing the aviation & tourism sector to settle reverse charge GST via accumulated credits would provide critical relief," he said. **PENDING ISSUES** Adding to the list of pending issues, Rajat Mohan, Managing Partner at AMRG Global, felt that delay is resulting in deferment of several crucial tax and compliance developments that businesses have been closely monitoring. "These include pending policy clarifications on interpretational and sector-specific issues, procedural simplification measures, and the pace of rollout and stabilisation of tech-driven compliance reforms such as the Invoice Management System (IMS)," he said. While IMS is operationally driven through GSTN, significant compliance

transformations tend to progress more effectively when supported by clear policy direction and institutional alignment, Mohan added. Sudipta Bhattacharjee, Partner at Khaitan & Co, opined that delays in GST Council meetings can slow down the pace of structural reforms as well as long-awaited clarifications on various industry issues. Without timely consensus, businesses may face prolonged uncertainty on compliance and pricing, which can dampen investment sentiment - especially in the current uncertain times. "While post GST 2.0 the GST framework is quite stable, regular GST Council meetings should be a priority to ensure quick resolution of industry-wide issues/ambiguities and certainty of tax positions which contribute significantly towards ease of doing business," he said. Agarwal added that prolonged gaps in GST Council meetings create business uncertainty and defer vital structural reforms. Mohan opined that extended delays in convening the GST Council can create practical bottlenecks, as several policies, procedural, and implementation matters effectively require collective consensus before moving forward.

EXIM Bank eyes 10% jump in loan book in FY27

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

The Export-Import Bank of India is aiming for a 10 per cent jump in its loan book in the financial year 2026-27, despite the West Asia conflict, a top official has said. The city-headquartered lender, which supports Indian exporters, is aiming for 10 per cent credit growth in the new fiscal, its Managing Director and Chief Executive Harsha Bangari said.

The FY27 loan growth number is lower than the 12 per cent growth it achieved in FY26, but currency fluctuation had a significant role in lifting the number. "Fifty-eight per cent of our loan book is foreign currency-denominated, while the rest is in rupees. The currency fluctuations had a positive impact of up to 5 per cent on the FY26 loan growth number," Bangari told *PTI*. The 10 per cent growth in the loan book in FY27 is

aimed at on a constant-currency basis, she clarified. The bank sees continued demand for financing from exporters, she said, adding that going forward, she expects the share of rupee loans to rise further. A bulk of the lending being done by Exim Bank is for medium to long-term, which is typically not impacted so much by aspects like the geopolitical tensions in West Asia. When asked about the impact of the West Asia con-

flict, she said the bank has a very small exposure to the region and added that the repayments have not been impacted. There may, however, be some impact on incremental credit growth as project activity stalls in the region, she said. If the crisis prolongs, exporters' margins may come under stress due to supply chain disruptions, and they may look at shifting their focus to the domestic market for revenue expansion, she said.

STATEMENT OF CONSOLIDATED AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS
FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED MARCH 31, 2026

(₹ in Millions, except per share data)

Particulars	Quarter Ended		Year Ended	
	31-Mar-2026 (Audited)	31-Mar-2025 (Audited)	31-Mar-2026 (Audited)	31-Mar-2025 (Audited)
Total Income from Operations	6,796	5,380	21,811	20,058
Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before Tax (before Exceptional items)	1,344	1,321	4,888	4,886
Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before Tax (after Exceptional items)	1,344	1,321	4,731	4,886
Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after Tax	1,019	946	3,494	3,586
Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after Tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after Tax)]	1,137	917	3,659	3,604
Equity Share Capital	318	318	318	318
Other Equity			14,142	11,846
Earnings per share of ₹1/- each (not annualised)				
(a) Basic (in ₹)	3.21	2.99	11.00	11.28
(b) Diluted (in ₹)	3.21	2.99	11.00	11.28

Notes:
1. Summarised Standalone Audited Financial Performance of the Company is as under:

Particulars	Quarter Ended		Year Ended	
	31-Mar-2026 (Audited)	31-Mar-2025 (Audited)	31-Mar-2026 (Audited)	31-Mar-2025 (Audited)
Total Income from Operations	6,025	4,904	20,097	17,952
Profit/(Loss) before Tax (before Exceptional items)	1,085	1,298	4,703	4,581
Profit/(Loss) before Tax (after Exceptional items) (Refer note 3)	1,085	1,298	4,546	4,941
Profit/(Loss) after Tax	789	937	3,367	3,744
Total Comprehensive Income	818	894	3,309	3,715

2 The above is an extract of the detailed format of Audited Financial Results for the Quarter and Year ended March 31, 2026 filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Financial Results for the Quarter and Year ended March 31, 2026 are available on the Stock Exchange websites (www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and on the Company's website (www.triveniturbines.com).

3 The Government of India has merged various existing labour laws into a unified framework comprising four labour codes, collectively referred to as the "New Labour Code". Accordingly, the Company has recognised a one-time impact of ₹157 million in compliance with Ind AS 19, relating to changes in employee benefit obligations during the previous quarter, and accordingly presented this amount as an exceptional item in the Statement of Profit and Loss for the year ended March 31, 2026. Following the notification of Central Rules, the Company continues to monitor the developments relating to the State Rules under the New Labour Code and will give appropriate accounting effect as and when the State Rules are notified.

4 The Board of Directors have recommended payment of final dividend @ 200% (₹2.00 per equity share of ₹1/- each) for the financial year 2025-26, in addition to the interim dividend of 225% (₹2.25 per equity share of ₹1/- each) paid during the current quarter. Final dividend is subject to approval of shareholders.

For TRIVENI TURBINE LIMITED
Sd/-
Dhruv M. Sawhney
Chairman & Managing Director

Registered & Corporate Office: 401, BPTP Capital City, Sector-94, Noida, Uttar Pradesh - 201 301
Website: www.triveniturbines.com | CIN: L29110UP1995PLC041834

Future shock

Q4 results strong but momentum under question

India Inc has sprung a surprise by reporting good growth for the January to March quarter of 2026. This is even as markets have been correcting on relentless selling by foreign investors. An analysis of Q4 results shows that 650 companies which have so far reported their numbers, managed a sharp improvement in revenue growth to 13.7 per cent with healthy profit growth of 17.8 per cent over the same quarter last year.



Revenue growth accelerated from 11.7 per cent in Q3 and 8 per cent in the preceding two quarters respectively, while profit growth has gathered pace from 11.2 per cent in Q3 and 6.5-7 per cent in the first two quarters. Operating profit margins improved to 30.3 per cent for Q4 FY26, compared to 26.3 per cent in the preceding quarter despite commodity inflation. However, these numbers don't reflect results from oil majors. Whether the earnings momentum will sustain as the real impact of ongoing energy shock and supply chain disruptions plays out, remains to be seen.

There are many takeaways from a macro economy perspective. One, both the urban and rural legs of the consumption economy fired in tandem this quarter. While good revenue growth for FMCG (14 per cent growth) and retail (12 per cent growth) showed healthy spends on staples; discretionary consumption also received a boost going by the sales growth momentum in automobiles (30 per cent revenue growth), e-commerce (141 per cent), realty (35 per cent), financial services (48 per cent) and jewellery (47 per cent). This suggests that the demand stimulus from the GST cuts announced in September 2025 have carried forward so far. Two, investment spending did well in pockets, going by revenue acceleration in segments such as railways (28 per cent growth), electrical goods (43 per cent) and power equipment (131 per cent). Three, India Inc's margins displayed resilience to spiralling energy, chemical and metal prices due to the war. However, companies were still using up inventories of industrial inputs. Rupee depreciation bolstering realisations for services exporters, could also have offset the margin hit taken by manufacturing companies. The real test of this will lie in whether current margins sustain once input inventories are depleted.

Four, companies reported improving interest coverage (7.5 times against 7.1 times at the same time last year), despite the rise in borrowing costs, suggesting that they remained frugal on debt. On the flip side though, India Inc continued to be reluctant to share its growth bounty with employees. As revenues expanded nearly 14 per cent and profits 18 per cent year-on-year, employee costs dropped to 13.8 per cent of revenues from 14.5 per cent a year ago. This shows wages growing more slowly than corporate profits — a worrying trend given that enterprise AI adoption has not even begun. Overall, while the fiscal year FY26 has closed on a positive note, FY27 may be a different ballgame, where inflation tests consumer spending, and increase in input costs squeezes margins.

POCKET

RAVIKANTH



India-New Zealand trade pact: Beyond a small market

TRADE PUSH. The FTA can boost Indian pharma and services, while New Zealand can gain in agri exports

GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO



VS SESHADRI

India and New Zealand signed their bilateral Free Trade Agreement on April 27, adding another partner to India's steadily expanding FTA network, which now covers all RCEP countries except China.

By itself, New Zealand may not appear a large market. With a population of just 5.3 million and annual imports from India of only around \$700 million — barely 1.8 per cent of New Zealand's imports — the commercial gains may seem modest.

Yet, at a time when India urgently needs to diversify and expand exports — merchandise exports in 2025-26 financing only about 57 per cent of imports — every additional market matters. The presence of a 3,00,000-strong Indian diaspora in New Zealand is also a major agricultural services exports further strengthen the case for the agreement.

The FTA grants duty-free access from day one for all Indian products entering New Zealand. While New Zealand's average MFN tariff is low at around 2 per cent, and nearly two-thirds of its tariff lines are already duty free, some labour-intensive sectors important for India face significantly higher tariffs.

SECTORS TO BENEFIT

Garments, for instance, attract average duties of nearly 10 per cent, while several footwear and textile items also face higher rates. Indian exporters in these sectors will now obtain parity with competitors from China and ASEAN countries that already enjoy preferential access to the New Zealand market. Penetrating that market will still require sustained export promotion, but tariff-free access certainly helps.

Indian generic pharmaceuticals,

currently accounting for exports of around \$60 million, stand to benefit as well. Side letters accompanying the FTA confirm that New Zealand recognises approvals granted by regulators in Australia, the EU, Canada, Singapore, the UK, Switzerland and the US as comparable to their own. This could significantly expedite regulatory approvals for Indian prescription medicines, including generics and biosimilars, as well as medical devices already cleared by those regulators.

Other important Indian exports to New Zealand include shrimps, spices, tea, coffee, rice, gold jewellery, electrical machinery, auto components and refined petroleum products. Tariffs on these products vary, particularly for processed agricultural items such as spices. The move to zero tariffs across the board should therefore improve competitiveness for Indian exporters.

On the import side, New Zealand exports mainly primary products to India — wood and wood pulp, steel and aluminium scrap, coal and wool — many of which serve as industrial inputs. New Zealand is also a major agricultural exporter. Fresh fruits are among its leading exports to India, and the FTA provides limited tariff-rate quota access for apples, kiwifruit, albumins and Manuka honey.

Interestingly, the agreement incorporates seasonal safeguards reflecting New Zealand's geographical advantage. Apple imports under the tariff quota will be permitted only from April to August, and kiwifruit from April to mid-October — periods that largely do not coincide with the Indian harvest

Fresh fruits are among New Zealand's leading exports to India, and the FTA provides limited tariff-rate quota access for apples, kiwifruit, albumins and Manuka honey

season. Minimum import price conditions will also apply.

As in India's recent FTAs with other partners, wine tariffs will be reduced gradually depending on price bands. Dairy products, however, remain fully excluded. Overall, around 29 per cent of tariff lines have been kept outside tariff liberalisation, broadly similar to the exclusion levels under India's ECTA with Australia.

SERVICES POTENTIAL

Services trade presents another important dimension. According to New Zealand's figures available at disaggregated levels, its services exports to India amounted to NZ\$1.14 billion in 2025 (1 US\$ equals around 1.68 NZ\$) somewhat exceeding its merchandise exports. Nearly 95 per cent of this comes from travel services, especially education-related travel spending by Indian students.

India's own services exports to New Zealand are considerably smaller at around NZ\$470 million, and computer and business services account for around only NZ\$110 million. This area offers substantial growth potential. The FTA provides greater certainty regarding visas for intra-corporate transferees, installers and servicers, independent professionals, and accompanying dependants.

Additionally, the agreement creates a new Temporary Employment Entry visa pathway with an annual quota of 5,000 visas for skilled Indian professionals for stays of up to three years. Covered sectors include IT, engineering, healthcare, education and construction, while professionals such as AYUSH practitioners, yoga instructors, Indian chefs and music teachers are also eligible. There is also an Annex on student mobility and post study work visa and a separate understanding on holiday work visas.

One particularly noteworthy provision is New Zealand's commitment to facilitate \$20 billion in FDI inflows into India over a 15-year period, echoing

a similar feature in India's FTA with the EFTA countries. Achieving this target, however, will not be easy. New Zealand's cumulative FDI into India since 2000 amounts to only around \$88 million. Considerable effort from both governments and industry bodies will be required to generate investor interest.

Two additional provisions could nevertheless create useful opportunities. First, the agreement provides for economic and technical cooperation in sectors such as horticulture, apiculture, livestock, fisheries, wines and organics — areas where New Zealand possesses significant expertise.

Second, India has committed to a fast-track arrangement allowing duty-free imports from New Zealand for products used exclusively for further processing and re-export. This facility could potentially extend even to dairy inputs otherwise excluded from the FTA.

The dedicated New Zealand investment desk that India is required to establish under the agreement should therefore work proactively to integrate these various provisions into concrete investment initiatives. There may be significant opportunities, for instance, for New Zealand investors and Indian partners to collaborate in export-oriented agro-processing ventures using duty-free New Zealand inputs for value-added exports from India.

Ultimately, FTAs are only enabling frameworks. Their success depends on the quality of follow-up — export promotion, investment facilitation and business-to-business engagement. India's mission in New Zealand can also play an important role in ensuring that this agreement evolves from a modest bilateral arrangement into a meaningful economic partnership. New Zealand's leaders have already termed it a 'once-in-a-generation pact'.

The writer is former Ambassador and Senior Fellow, Delhi Policy Group

Getting retail investors to 'samba' with bonds

India can emulate Brazil in offering tax sops to bond investors to boost investments into infrastructure

Subodh Rai

India needs a massive infrastructure buildout to realise its Viksit Bharat vision. Funding that buildout, in turn, requires a rebalancing of investment flows to achieve a well-rounded financial ecosystem, with a symbiotic relationship between the bond and equity markets, along with higher retail participation.

Currently, retail investors in India, especially the middle class and corporate employees, are significantly more invested in equity markets compared with bond markets. The equity tilt exposes them to market volatility, such as those caused by the ongoing geopolitical and trade related uncertainties.

To mitigate this risk, retail investors should be encouraged to diversify into fixed-income products through bond markets that face lower volatility in yields and offer benefits of fixed long-term returns.

To be sure, returns on investments in infrastructure have been resilient to a large extent during periods of uncertainty. This makes bond market investments in targeted sectors such as infrastructure a promising avenue for retail investors. The experience of Brazil — also a developing economy — throws up some takeaways for promoting a culture of retail investments in bond

market and, thereby, fuel infrastructure development.

BRAZIL'S SUCCESS STORY

Brazil has successfully channelled retail savings into the bond market by offering tax exemptions on 'incentivised debentures' that fund infrastructure projects.

In 2011, Brazil introduced a framework for issuance of debentures that provided the retail investors with an exemption for interest and capital gain income from specific bonds targeted to finance infrastructure expenditure.

Until 2016, the Brazilian Development Bank, BNDES (Banco Nacional de Desenvolvimento Econômico e Social), used to be the primary source of funding for infrastructure projects.

Since then, however, with increasing familiarity, incentivised debentures have gained traction with retail investors, and more projects turned towards them to raise funds. Over the past 7-8 years, these debentures have grown to garner the majority share in funding private infrastructure projects in Brazil, much higher than disbursements by BNDES.

BENEFITS FOR INDIA

This approach to offer tax benefits can be emulated in the Indian context. If a small portion of household savings is



BONDS. Luring investors

incrementally directed towards bond markets, it can bring a material change in the process of long-term nation-building.

Our calculations show that if incremental savings equivalent to 10 per cent of retail systematic investment plan (SIP) inflow in equity mutual funds are channelled to the bond market, this can:

- * Increase gross domestic product (GDP) by 30-40 basis points (bps) over the next few years, assuming multiplier effect for infrastructure investments (using multiplier as quoted in Official Budget debate in Rajya Sabha);
- * Boost annual infrastructure investments by 2-3 per cent on the base of fiscal 2025.

Per our analysis, the incremental tax revenue that can be generated over the next few years from additional GDP unlocked by infrastructure investments would be approximately 0.05 per cent of the GDP (fiscal 2025 base) assuming a

tax to GDP ratio of around 12 per cent.

That potential gain will significantly outweigh the upfront fiscal sacrifice of around 0.02 per cent of annual GDP, which represents the tax revenue forgone on the interest income being realised by retail investors over the lifespan of the infrastructure-targeted bonds.

Notably, India has implemented policies involving upfront fiscal sacrifices for sustainable self-reliant economic growth in the past, such as the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme.

To encourage retail participation, the government could offer tax-free status to income on bonds that fund key target sectors such as infrastructure. This approach can provide an attractive fixed-income investment option to investors, while bringing in a diverse set of investors to bond markets.

A well-developed bond market can also fuel private sector investments in infrastructure projects, complementing the government's direct infrastructure investments and creating a multiplier effect on economic growth.

Thus, by adapting Brazil's success story to the Indian context, we can establish a more balanced and diversified financial ecosystem, better equipped to support India's long-term vision of a Viksit Bharat.

The writer is Managing Director, Crisil Ratings Ltd

✉ LETTERS TO EDITOR Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Dutch connect

Apropos 'India, Netherlands ink 17 pacts on defence, critical minerals', (May 18). The signing of 17 agreements between India and the Netherlands marks a substantive expansion of strategic and economic cooperation amid mounting geopolitical uncertainties. Covering defence, critical minerals, semiconductors, maritime security and green technologies, the pacts reflect a concerted endeavour to build resilient supply chains and diminish overreliance on concentrated global sources. India stands to benefit from Dutch

technological expertise and logistical efficiency, while the Netherlands secures deeper engagement with a rapidly growing Indo-Pacific power. Beyond commerce, the accords signify Europe's increasing strategic alignment with India in safeguarding economic stability, technological sovereignty and regional security in an increasingly fractured global order. **N Sadhasiva Reddy** Bengaluru

Sabari rail benefit

This refers to 'Sabari Rail: An answered prayer?' (May 18). The

much awaited Sabari new Rail line conceived and sanctioned in 1998 is yet to see any visible progress despite loss of precious three decades. It is much evident that Kerala was ruled by a non NDA government. Setting aside the political controversies arising, this rail network is expected to boost religious tourism and much touted to be most beneficial route both from improvising pilgrimage based tourism and transport local produce of paddy, spices, rubber, pineapple and local woods to upcountry markets.

Necessary clearance from Environmental Ministry under the current provisions must be on record before pursuing with this new rail line. **RV Baskaran** Pune

Bengal's challenges

Apropos the Editorial 'Beyond the Ballot' (May 18), Suwendu Adhikari inherits a State with genuine latent strengths — geography, intellectual capital, port access — but also a debt burden of 38 per cent of State GDP and decades of deindustrialisation that no electoral mandate can

quickly reverse. What makes the early signs troubling is not administrative ambition but the communal undertone. A Chief Minister's declaration that his government will work only for Hindus is constitutionally incompatible with the office he holds. Bengal's revival depends on investment confidence and social stability. Neither is possible if governance begins by narrowing the circle of belonging rather than widening it. **A Myilsami** Coimbatore



QUICKLY.

Mangalam Worldwide
okays 10-for-1 stock split



Mumbai: The board of Mangalam Worldwide Ltd (MWL), an Ahmedabad-based stainless steel manufacturer listed on the NSE-SME platform, on Monday approved a proposal to split its equity shares in a 10-for-1 ratio, reducing the face value from ₹10 to ₹1 per share. Alongside the split, the board approved a proposal for direct listing on the BSE main board, pending approval from the exchange and relevant authorities. The company also approved a consequential amendment to the Capital Clause of its Memorandum of Association. The moves come on the back of MWL's financial results for FY26, in which it reported revenue of ₹1,214.98 crore and profit after tax of ₹50.14 crore. The stock on Monday closed at ₹365.70. The company came out with IPO at ₹101 a share in June-July 2022. **OUR BUREAU**

Liberty Mutual increases
LGI stake to 74%

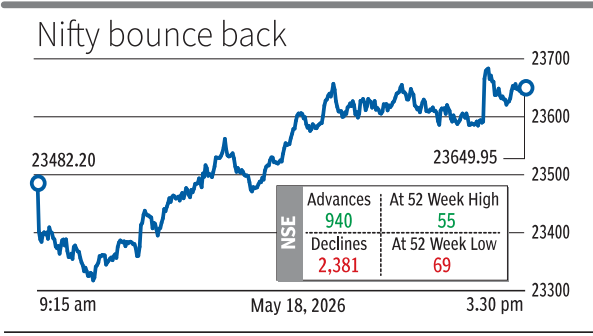
Mumbai: Liberty Mutual Insurance has increased its shareholding in Liberty General Insurance (LGI) to 74 per cent, the US-based insurer announced in Mumbai on Monday. The move follows an earlier stake increase from 49 per cent to 55.40 per cent in September 2025, marking a continued push by the American insurer to deepen its presence in the Indian market. The remaining 26 per cent stake in LGI is held by Enam Securities. Liberty Mutual's holding is structured through Summit Asia Investments Holdings Pte Ltd, a group company of Liberty Mutual Insurance Group. **OUR BUREAU**

Nifty recoups from 23,317 low on short covering

CHANGE OF MOOD. Foreign portfolio investors turn buyers for ₹2,814 crore; beaten down information technology stocks led market recovery with sharp gains

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

The markets staged a dramatic intra-day recovery on Monday after nearly losing 400 points from the open, as the Nifty 50 crawled back from an intra-day low of 23,317 to close almost flat, even as a collapsing rupee, Brent crude above \$100 a barrel, and renewed US-Iran hostilities kept investors on edge through the session. According to analysts, the recovery was mainly on the account of FPI buying and short-covering. “Markets witnessed a volatile session on Monday, with benchmark indices ending almost unchanged amid weak global cues and persistent macroeconomic concerns... the Nifty ended largely unchanged at 23,649.95,” said Ajit Mishra, SVP Research at Religare



Broking. The Nifty 50 settled at 23,649.95, up just 6.45 points, while the BSE Sensex gained 77.05 points to close at 75,315.04. Nifty had opened with a gap-down of 161 points at 23,482 and declined further to hit a low of 23,317.10 before buyers stepped in aggressively, helping it recover more than 330 points from the day's low. Similarly, BSE staged a recovery of about 1,285 points from day's low.

According to NSE provisional data, FPIs bought shares worth ₹2,6814 crore on Monday; they pulled out nearly ₹2.2 lakh crore in 2026 so far. Geopolitical developments kept investors unsettled throughout the day. Donald Trump's fresh warning to Iran, reports of a drone attack at a UAE nuclear facility, and an ongoing deadlock over the Strait of Hormuz collectively stoked

fears of supply disruption and risk-off sentiment globally.

TECH SURGE

On the sectoral front, IT was the clear outperformer, with Nifty IT surging 2.43 per cent as a depreciating rupee boosted earnings prospects for dollar-revenue exporters and bargain hunters moved into names that had been beaten down on AI disruption fears. Tech Mahindra and Infosys were the top gainers in the Nifty 50. Pharma and healthcare also posted modest gains. On the other side, Nifty Media and Nifty PSU Bank led the declines, with Auto, Consumer Durables, and Realty also ending in the red. Tata Steel and Power Grid were among the prominent losers. In the broader market, the Nifty Midcap 100 managed a marginal decline of 0.15 per

cent after rebounding from a swing low zone of around 59,460–59,560, while the Nifty Smallcap 100 underperformed sharply, falling

1.26 per cent. Going forward, technicals suggest the Nifty faces immediate resistance in the 23,700–23,800 zone. With weekly derivat-

ives expiry approaching and India VIX elevated, options premiums are significantly inflated, adding complexity to hedging strategies.

Market-cap race: Bharti Airtel
closing in on HDFC Bank for No 2 spot

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Bharti Airtel briefly overtook HDFC Bank on Monday to become India's second-largest company by market capitalisation, but marginal losses in its shares towards the close pushed it back to third place. Bharti Airtel shares climbed 1.72 per cent to ₹1,938.10 on the NSE. Airtel's total market cap stood at ₹11,80,328 crore, just behind HDFC Bank's ₹11,82,223 crore — a gap that

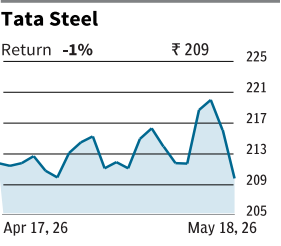
fluctuated through the session after Airtel hit an intra-day high of ₹1,953.80. Reliance Industries remains the country's most valuable firm at ₹18.04 lakh crore. The Airtel stock has gained over 10 per cent in the past week and outperformed the broader market significantly, with one-year returns of 6.8 per cent against the Nifty 50's negative 5.54 per cent. HDFC Bank, by contrast, has shed 22.53 per cent year-to-date and 20.63 per cent over the past year, weighed

down by the abrupt resignation of its part-time Chairman Atanu Chakraborty. Airtel's rise comes on the back of solid Q4 FY26 results. Revenue from operations grew 15.6 per cent year-on-year to ₹55,383 crore, while India mobile revenue rose 8.3 per cent, supported by higher average revenue per user (ARPU), which improved to ₹257 from ₹245 a year ago. Net profit fell 33.5 per cent to ₹7,325 crore, largely due to a high base from one-time gains in the year-ago quarter.

Tata Steel slips 3% post Q4, analysts divided

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Tata Steel shares declined 3.3 per cent to ₹209.71 on the NSE on Monday after investors reacted cautiously to the company's March quarter earnings and mixed brokerage commentary, with concerns around regulatory headwinds in Europe and delays in key overseas projects weighing on sentiment despite a sharp rise in profit. The company reported a more than two-fold jump in consolidated net profit for the March quarter at ₹2,965 crore, compared to ₹1,200 crore in the year-ago period, aided by better realisations. Brokerages maintained a



mixed stance on the stock following the results. Jefferies maintained a 'Buy' rating and raised its price target to ₹275. It increased its FY27 and FY28 EPS estimates by 6 per cent to 14 per cent and expects the India business to deliver 9 per cent volume growth along with margin expansion in FY27. It said India remains the key driver for Tata Steel's stock perform-

ance despite ongoing regulatory concerns in Europe. Morgan Stanley retained its 'Overweight' with a price target of ₹215. The brokerage said Tata Steel delivered a strong performance across domestic and overseas operations and expects the near-term outlook to remain favourable, aided by higher India prices and policy support in the UK and EU.

NETHERLANDS WOES

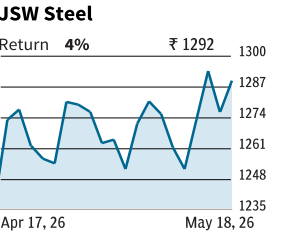
However, JPMorgan downgraded the stock to 'Neutral' with a price target of ₹220 after the stock rallied 38 per cent over the past year, compared to a 5.5 per cent decline in the Nifty. The brokerage cited regulatory cost pressures in the Netherlands

business, including risks linked to early closure of coke and gas plants, which could increase raw material, freight and employee restructuring costs. CLSA maintained a 'Hold' rating on Tata Steel with a price target of ₹225. Investec retained 'Hold' with a target price of ₹240, citing strong earnings supported by resilient India operations and reduced losses in Europe. Goldman Sachs maintained a 'Neutral' rating with a price target of ₹218. Meanwhile, Citi retained 'Sell' with a target of ₹200, as it remained cautious due to uncertainty around environmental regulations in the Netherlands and slower growth visibility beyond FY27.

SBI Mutual Fund, GQG Partners buy
1% stake in JSW Steel for ₹3,150 crore

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

SBI Mutual Fund and GQG Partners on Monday bought a combined stake of 1.02 per cent in JSW Steel from promoter company JSW Energy Ltd for ₹3,150 crore through open market transactions. A total of 2.5 crore equity shares or 1.02 per cent stake were acquired by the two entities, according to the block deal data on the NSE. SBI Mutual Fund purchased 1 crore shares, representing a 0.41 per cent stake in Mumbai-based JSW Steel. In addition, US-based in-



vestment firm GQG Partners through its affiliate GQG Partners Emerging Markets Equity Fund acquired 1.5 crore shares, or 0.61 per cent stake in Sajjan Jindal-led JSW Steel, as per the data. The shares were acquired at an average price of ₹1,260, taking the combined trans-

action value to ₹3,150 crore. After the latest transaction, SBI Mutual Fund's holding in JSW Steel rose to 1.57 per cent from 1.16 per cent. Meanwhile, JSW Energy sold the equal number of shares at the same price. Following the completion of transaction, JSW Energy's shareholding in JSW Steel fell to 1.84 per cent from 2.86 per cent. Earlier, JSW Energy said it had offloaded 2.5 crore equity shares in JSW Steel for ₹3,150 crore as part of a strategic liquidity release. Shares of JSW Steel rose nearly 1 per cent to close at ₹1,292.80 apiece on the NSE.

India-focused funds see biggest
outflows since 2020: Morningstar

Our Bureau
Mumbai

India-focused offshore funds and ETFs witnessed net outflows of nearly \$5 billion during the quarter ended March 2026, marking the sharpest quarterly pull back since the pandemic-led sell-off in 2020, according to a report by Morningstar. They together recorded net outflows of \$4.97 billion during the March quarter, sharply higher than the \$1.8 billion outflow seen in the December 2025 quarter. Of the total outflows, India-focused offshore funds accounted for \$3.46 billion, while offshore ETFs saw outflows of around \$1.5 billion.

FII SELLING

Foreign institutional investors (FIIs) remained net sellers in Indian equities during the March quarter, with cumulative net outflows of nearly \$14.2 billion. This was due to heightened global uncertainty, geopolitical tensions, rising risk aversion among



foreign investors, and profit booking amid elevated valuations in Indian equities. The BSE Sensex declined 15.5 per cent during the quarter, while the Nifty 50 index dropped 14.54 per cent amid a broad-based correction in equities. India-focused offshore funds and ETFs as a category delivered negative returns of 17.6 per cent during the quarter, although they marginally outperformed the MSCI India USD Index, which declined 18.1 per cent. The quarter witnessed geopolitical tensions in West Asia involving the US, Israel and Iran, alongside a stronger dollar, elevated US bond yields and surging crude oil prices, all of which hurt risk appetite for emer-

ging markets such as India. “Valuations became disconnected from near-term earnings visibility, leading to a recalibration in market expectations,” the report said. **AUM DECLINE** The sharp correction in Indian equities also eroded the asset base of offshore India-focused products. Assets under management of India-focused offshore funds and ETFs fell 19.5 per cent quarter-on-quarter to \$77 billion at the end of March 2026 from about \$96 billion in the previous quarter. Within this, offshore ETFs accounted for \$24.1 billion while offshore funds held \$52.9 billion in assets. Morningstar said offshore ETFs continued to display greater resilience than actively managed offshore funds. “ETFs also offer easier exit options and greater cost efficiency than funds,” the report said, adding that foreign investors increasingly use ETFs as a “flexible means to quickly move in and out of India's equity markets.”

Indian markets capable of absorbing
shocks: SEBI chief on West Asia crisis

Press Trust of India
Bhubaneswar

Volatility has shot up in the financial markets due to the ongoing West Asia conflict, but the Indian bourses have the capacity to “absorb different types of shocks,” SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said on Monday. When there is a crisis in one part of the world, it also impacts the rest of the globe, Pandey told reporters on the sidelines of the Regional Investors Seminar for Awareness. “Due to West Asia conflict, the oil supply chain and its prices got affected in the rest of the world. All the economies have been affected by this and obviously, there are inflationary risks. Besides, spillover effect and second-

order effect will also come in,” he said. “However, the advantages of a resilient Indian market are that it is able to absorb different types of shocks, and when these end, the market again resumes its normal trajectory,” Pandey said. He also admitted that there have been some foreign portfolio investment outflows since September 2024, but domestic investors have “retained their confidence.” **AI RISKS** Asked how SEBI is addressing threats from AI tools, Pandey said, “Most of the recent concerns around such tools are related to cybersecurity. As you know, markets rely heavily on software systems, and if cybersecurity is threatened or vulnerabilities

are found in the software, there is a risk of attacks. If such attacks are successful, they can pose a serious threat to market integrity.” “Therefore, we have to proactively ensure that all the software we deploy, including those provided by third-party vendors, is well protected. There has to be aggressive patch management and extensive use of conventional tools to identify vulnerabilities,” the SEBI chief said. SEBI is using mechanism to ensure that the market, market ecosystem, and intermediaries are protected from any cyber risk, he asserted. Pandey also said that “fin-fluencers”, who give financial and stock-related advice, must first register themselves with SEBI.

BROKER'S CALL.

ICICI Securities

SEDEMAC MECHATRONICS (BUY)
Target: ₹2,350
CMP: ₹1,980.80

Sedemac Mechatronics is among the leading and few domestic players to have developed control-intensive, critical-to-the-application electronic control units (ECUs). Underpinned by the high-quality technical capabilities and strong engineering expertise of its founders, Sedemac has an established track record of delivering pioneering, first-to-market solutions that enable OEMs to offer a superior value proposition to end-users. Growing adoption of ISG in ICE 2Ws/3Ws and rising electrification. ISG penetration in the domestic 2W segment stands at about 36 per cent. Given the end-customer benefits (smoother starts to 2Ws/3Ws and better fuel efficiency), we expect ISG penetration to deepen further (to about 50 per cent by FY30E). Sedemac's unique sensorless commutation (SLC)-based ISG increases product reliability at lower costs by eliminating sensors, thereby expanding its use cases even to motorcycles (in addition to scooters). In 2Ws/3Ws augurs well. Further, Sedemac's proprietary sensorless commutation (SLC) technology provides it an edge over its peers and could aid its market share in both these segments. Expanding these SLC capabilities into large addressable areas could provide growth longevity. Initiating coverage on Sedemac with Buy and TP of ₹2,350. **Key risks:** SLC-based MCU adoption key to diversification and growth longevity; high import dependence for key raw materials increases supply chain and currency related risks; high customer concentration.

Choice International

DATA PATTERNS (ADD)
Target: ₹4,060
CMP: ₹3,754.70

We continue to remain positive on the company, but more importantly, the nature of the story is clearly evolving. From what we see, the company is no longer just building capabilities – it is now getting structurally embedded into key defence platforms. This is an important shift, because growth going ahead is likely to be driven more by its positioning within long-cycle programmes. What stood out to us is the increasing share of repeat, system-level opportunities (₹1,900 crore). This, along with the pipeline commentary, suggests that reported order book may not fully capture the revenue visibility. In our view, the company is now participating deeper across platform lifecycles (seekers, radars, EW, avionics), which typically leads to more predictable and compounding revenue streams over time. On margins, the management commentary was quite telling. It is evident that profitability here is less dependent on competition intensity and more on control over design. Wherever the company is delivering system-level work, margins are meaningfully better. So, while quarterly margins may move based on mix, we do not see structural pressure on profitability. Putting this together, we believe the company sits in a relatively niche position – high control, limited competition and increasing platform-level relevance. If execution sustains and pipeline conversion improves, earnings could surprise on the upside, though near-term trajectory will still depend on order inflows and execution pace.

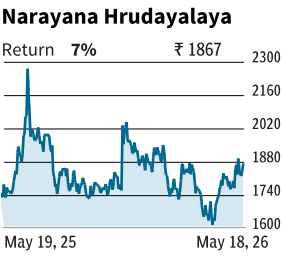
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TODAY'S PICK.

Narayana Hrudayalaya (₹1,867.95): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl_research bureau

The short-term outlook is bullish for Narayana Hrudayalaya. The stock has formed a good base around ₹1,800 and has now started to move up. Also, the base formation and the rise is happening from around a strong trend line support. This indicates that the broader uptrend is still intact. It also strengthens further the bullish case. Cluster of supports are there in the ₹1,845-₹1,825 region. Narayana Hrudayalaya share price can rise to ₹1,940-₹1,950 in the coming weeks. Traders can buy Narayana Hrudayalaya shares now at ₹1,868. Accumulate on dips at ₹1,848. Keep the stop-loss at



₹1,805 initially. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹1,880 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹1,895. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹1,895 and ₹1,915 when the share price touches ₹1,910 and ₹1,930 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹1,950. Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23659 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23580	23435	23740	23850	Take fresh longs only above 23740 with a stop-loss at 23710

₹769 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
766	760	774	785	Take fresh longs above 774. Keep the stop-loss at 772

₹1145 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1135	1115	1160	1180	Go long on dips at 1140. Stop-loss can be kept at 1130

₹310 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
308	306	312	315	Wait for dips. Go long at 309 with a stop-loss at 307

₹297 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
294	292	299	303	Go short now and at 298. Keep the stop-loss at 301

₹1335 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1315	1305	1345	1370	Wait for a rise. Go short at 1340 with a stop-loss at 1350

₹939 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
934	930	945	955	Go short only below 934. Stop-loss can be placed at 936

₹2290 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2265	2240	2305	2325	Go long on a break above 2305. Keep the stop-loss at 2295

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▲ 6.45 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Bharti Airtel	1938.10	21.88	34.91	5.48	
Infosys	1142.50	17.97	15.72	3.69	
ICICI Bank	1251.10	10.29	15.46	8.25	
Tech Mahindra	1430.00	8.24	29.16	0.84	
Kotak Bank	391.80	7.62	20.20	2.66	
Sun Pharma	1905.80	6.37	41.75	1.86	
Bajaj Finance	921.10	6.21	29.65	2.27	
TCS	2283.20	4.28	16.70	2.15	
HDFC Bank	768.65	3.84	14.93	10.85	
HCL Tech	1146.60	3.22	18.69	1.12	
Bajaj Finserv	1753.10	3.15	14.27	0.59	
JSW Steel	1292.80	2.86	12.39	1.12	
Bharat Elec	426.60	2.30	52.30	3.41	
L&T	3917.80	2.25	28.43	4.24	
UltraTech Cement	11561.00	1.91	41.61	1.26	
Titan	310.15	1.47	18.77	2.76	
Max Healthcare	1058.55	1.37	72.58	0.73	
Wipro	192.17	1.35	15.19	0.51	
Asian Paints	2614.00	0.83	64.13	1.09	
Grasim Ind	2943.80	0.83	21.15	1.03	
Eternal Ltd	241.40	0.35	636.50	1.60	
Nestle India	1431.70	0.19	78.90	0.95	
Titan	4169.70	0.05	72.98	8.32	
Coal India	462.10	-0.05	9.17	0.97	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	232.63	-0.31	94.68	0.70	
SBI Life	1860.40	-0.40	75.54	0.77	
TataConsumerProduct	1231.00	-0.43	78.75	0.74	
Cipla	1426.20	-0.72	29.83	0.74	
Dy Reddys Lab	1331.20	-0.73	26.72	0.75	
Reliance Ind	1237.80	-0.74	18.88	8.32	
HDFC Life	604.95	-0.88	68.25	0.60	
Adani Ports	1787.70	-1.19	32.22	1.22	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	933.70	-1.28	21.91	1.21	
Apollo Hosp	8020.50	-1.39	61.81	0.76	
Tata Motors PV	353.15	-1.55	4335.06	0.68	
Adani Enter	2090.90	-6.21	34.27	0.71	
ONGC	297.20	-1.82	8.31	1.06	
Int'l GloBeavi	4275.70	-1.93	51.48	0.89	
Eicher Motors	6913.00	-3.05	35.40	0.88	
Trent Ltd.	4032.30	-3.34	83.27	0.82	
Hind Unilever	2254.20	-3.48	50.05	1.84	
Abs Bank	1237.80	-4.32	11.49	3.27	
Bajaj Auto	10198.50	-4.32	26.96	1.04	
Hindalco	1053.10	-4.54	14.72	1.41	
Maruti Suzuki	13016.00	-5.87	27.88	1.57	
NTPC	388.30	-7.18	15.17	1.70	
M&M	3083.70	-7.68	20.59	2.54	
PowerGrid Corp	296.55	-7.18	17.77	1.24	
Tata Steel	2097.10	-12.82	59.74	1.85	
State Bank	939.40	-21.53	10.01	3.59	
Pts: Impact on index movement					
Nifty Next 50 Movers					▼ 662.25 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Solar Industries	18019.00	48.48	106.80	1.81	
Varun Beverages	511.50	29.75	53.90	2.88	
Ltintimtree	4074.60	27.82	24.25	1.56	
Divis Lab.	6835.00	26.73	73.19	3.57	
Adani Energy Solutions	1328.30	24.19	66.09	1.90	
Dif	573.15	11.59	32.14	1.51	
Tata Motors Cv	379.80	10.91	46.19	3.27	
Bajaj Holdings	10367.00	7.21	11.79	1	
Macrotech Developers	85.75	6.20	24.97	0.99	
Abb India	6413.50	4.81	86.01	1.38	
Jindal Steel	1231.80	-0.21	37.39	1.88	
Hindus Zyn	636.50	-1.59	19.44	1.14	
Torrent Pharma	4393.70	-3.54	65.45	1.89	
United Spirits	4170.70	-4.17	55.61	1.80	
Tata Capital	302.95	-6.10	26.29	0.54	
Ambuja Cements	430.15	-6.20	19.34	1.08	
Muthootfin	3290.90	-6.21	15.27	1.45	
Siemens Energy India	3060.70	-6.34	92.27	1.11	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	91.66	-6.81	16.21	0.81	
Bank of Baroda	260.05	-7.07	6.70	1.98	
Mazagon Dock	2444.30	-8.04	35.78	0.76	
Britannia Ind	5380.50	-8.48	51.08	2.61	
AdaniGreenenergy	1360.99	-9.46	113.49	1.89	
Tata Power	404.35	-12.52	25.25	2.78	
Siemens	3535.10	-13.17	79.40	1.29	
Avanija	3715.00	-14.32	92.40	1.33	
Gail (India)	160.22	-14.54	12.74	1.75	
Zydusfisciences	99.10	-14.55	19.84	1.02	
Samarasmothersoninternatl	128.75	-14.62	37.34	2.34	
Pdindind	1450.20	-15.32	59.74	1.85	
Unilever	158.69	-16.61	62.46	1.26	
India Motor India	117.15	-17.43	26.65	1.95	
Shree Cement	24475.00	-18.69	50.50	1.35	
Indian Hotels Co.	648.55	-19.09	41.08	2.34	
Vedanta	327.00	-19.43	8.06	2.29	
Bpcl	280.80	-20.88	4.95	2.34	
Cholamandalamin&fin	1527.90	-22.25	24.87	2.69	
Avanija	142.50	-22.84	94.62	1.61	
Adani Power	219.30	-23.70	32.62	2.61	
Punjab Natl Bank	99.49	-24.92	6.19	1.41	
Godrej Consumer	1014.40	-28.16	55.76	1.68	
Indian Oilcorp	131.81	-28.16	5.05	2.03	
Canara Bank	124.90	-30.17	6.34	1.73	
Indian Electronics	41.41	-31.97	31.74	3.38	
Cummins India	5298.50	-35.65	65.52	2.94	
Rural Elec	33.73	-42.84	5.39	1.71	
Hdfc Amc	2625.10	-45.09	39.35	2.20	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	808.75	-57.04	106.43	2.28	
Power Finance	42.80	-65.56	4.22	2.57	
Tps Motor Comp.	3291.00	-116.55	49.07	3.18	
Pts: Impact on index movement					

QUICKLY.

MCX to facilitate delivery of India refined silver



Mumbai: MCX, the country's largest commodity exchange, has sought BIS-certified silver refiner's application to facilitate the delivery of domestically refined silver on the exchange platform. To pave the way for domestic silver refiners to deliver silver via the MCX platform, the exchange has revised the eligibility criteria for MCX Good Delivery Norms for BIS-Standard Gold/Silver. It has also changed the procedure for empanelment of domestic silver refiners in the MCX Good Delivery Norms for domestic gold/silver refiners. "Exchange hereby invites eligible domestic silver refiners to apply to be empanelled as per MCX Good Delivery Norms for domestic gold/silver refiners," it said in a circular on Monday. **OUR BUREAU**

Gold steady as Iran waiver report counters rate fears

Gold steadied as traders weighed the inflation risks from a lack of progress in reopening the Strait of Hormuz against Iranian media reports that the US has proposed a temporary waiver on oil sanctions. The US has accepted waiving the sanctions on Iran during peak talks, the semi-official *Tasnim news agency* reported. Oil erased an earlier gain. Bullion retreated almost 4 per cent last week, after the US and Iran remained far apart on a deal to end the war and reopen Hormuz. Spot gold edged higher \$4,553.37 an ounce as of 1:26 p.m. in London. Silver climbed 1.2 per cent, after falling more than 5 per cent last week. The Bloomberg dollar spot index was 0.2 per cent lower after gaining 1.2 per cent last week. **BLOOMBERG**

As government import curbs hit supply, silver to trade at a premium

TURNING PRICEY. ETFs gain momentum as tighter import rules reshape domestic precious metals market

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Silver mutual fund schemes and exchange-traded funds will see a short supply of the white metal with the government imposing curbs on imports.

Following the government curbs that require imports to get permits from the Directorate-General of Foreign Trade (DGFT), silver ETFs jumped between 4 per cent and 0.24 per cent on the stock exchange, bucking the weak price trend in the domestic markets.

Silver prices were down marginally at ₹268,040 a kg against ₹2,68,500 during the weekend, according to data from the Indian Bullion and Jewellers Association of India.

MFPS REPORT OUTFLOW
The demand for silver ETFs



TOUGH MEASURES. The latest curbs come within days of the government increasing the import duty on precious metals from 6 per cent to 15 per cent **REUTERS**

has suddenly picked up even as MFs have been reporting net outflow from silver funds in the last few months. This is a clear indication that equity investors are trying to diversify and take advantage of a possible rally in domestic silver prices due to short-supply in the coming days.

Silver ETFs are trading well below the indicative Net Asset Value (i-NAV) an-

nounced by MFs as domestic prices are at a discount of about \$1.5\$2 an ounce.

Satish Dondapati, Fund Manager, Kotak Mahindra AMC, said the import restriction may support Indian silver prices gradually over the coming months.

"Silver had already risen sharply in recent weeks mainly due to the duty hike, so some investors or traders

booked profits in the last 2-3 sessions. A large part of the positive impact was already reflected in prices earlier," he said.

IMPORT DUTY HIKE

In a notification, the DGFT on Saturday said the import policy for silver, including silver plated with gold and platinum, has been revised "from free to restricted" with immediate effect.

Goods placed under the "restricted" category can only be imported against a valid licence issued by the government.

The latest curbs come within days of the government increasing the import duty on precious metals from 6 per cent to 15 per cent. The revised structure includes a 10 per cent basic customs duty along with a 5 per cent Agriculture Infrastructure and Development Cess.

Silver imports crossed \$12

billion in fiscal year 2026, registering a 150 per cent jump from the previous year.

After a historic inflow of ₹3,962 crore and ₹9,463 crore in December and January, silver schemes of MFs have recorded a steady net outflow of ₹1,637 crore in the last three months as early investors booked profit after prices started moving down.

REDIRECTING SUPPLY

Renisha Chainani, Head of Research at Augmont, said the government is consciously redirecting India's silver supply chain away from import dependence toward domestic refining and reducing CAD pressure.

"The market will adjust, which will neither be quick nor painless. Silver market participants must now navigate a fundamentally different regulatory and supply landscape than existed even two weeks ago," she said.

ICAR's 113 research institutes to be overhauled

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Shivraj Singh Chouhan has ordered a comprehensive review of the functioning of the ICAR after expressing dissatisfaction at the functioning of the Pune-based National Research Centre for Grapes, where he went on a surprise visit. This signals the government's growing impatience with the pace and effectiveness of the farm research ecosystem.

Chouhan directed ML Jat, Director-General of the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR), to submit a detailed report on revamping

the organisation, indicating that the government will be looking at structural and accountability changes in the country's apex agricultural research network.

The move assumes significance as the government is pushing for higher farm productivity, climate-resilient crops and stronger export competitiveness in horticulture and allied sectors. The surprise visit also underscores a broader message from the government that research institutions will be increasingly subjected to performance scrutiny amid rising pressure to deliver commercially viable outcomes for farmers.



Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan **ANI**

SHORTCOMINGS

At the review meeting held on May 16, Chouhan laid down a clear direction on the functioning, accountability, quality and farmer-oriented results of ICAR's 113 research institutions, which are the pivot of the country's agricultural progress.

Chouhan expressed his displeasure and observed the shortcomings he found during a surprise inspection on May 15 at the National Research Centre for Grapes.

The Minister found that the head of the institute did not even have basic knowledge about the research centre.

"At first, I was requested to avoid visiting the field, saying there were no grapes yet. On reaching there, I saw that grass was growing in the nursery. How justified is the answer that workers are not available to cut? The key officials there could not give a proper answer to any of the questions when I asked what

they are doing for exports, the arrangements to deal with diseases, and the plan to increase varieties. None of the answers was satisfactory," he said.

"The presentation of the institute was also very monotonous. The farmers told me that they buy the varieties from private nurseries as the Institute's nursery is of no use," Chouhan said in a statement. The Minister told the senior officers of ICAR that he was deeply disappointed with the situation that unfolded during the inspection, and it was a clear indication that there is an urgent need for systemic reform in some of the institutions.

Loading of potatoes in cold storages rises 14% in West Bengal

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

Loading of potatoes in West Bengal cold storages has increased by 14 per cent to 74 lakh tonnes, as the State's production of the spud crossed 140 lakh tonnes for 2025-26, the highest in the last five years.

Total potato production in West Bengal, the country's second-largest grower, was around 115 lakh tonnes last year, which was also a bumper output.

"Total potato production for the State surpassed 140 lakh tonnes this year, backed by favourable weather conditions. Moreover, the area under cultivation increased marginally," Patit Paban De, a senior member of the West Bengal Cold Storage Association, told *businessline*.

Amid a record rise in potato production, loading



In West Bengal, land under potato cultivation was around 4.9 lakh hectares in 2024-25

in cold storages soared to 74 lakh tonnes from 65 lakh tonnes last year.

"More than 95 per cent of the storages are already full. This year, mostly farmers have loaded their produce. Traders have not shown much interest in loading in cold storage after suffering substantial financial loss last year," De said.

CRASH IN PRICES

Last year, wholesale potato

prices slumped in West Bengal as farmers across the State resorted to distress sales, while substantial stocks remained in cold storage after growers and traders witnessed a massive fall in inter-State trade.

Bengal had lost out in its major potato markets such as Odisha, Jharkhand and Bihar to Uttar Pradesh, which has been expanding its inter-State trade aggressively to capture these markets.

The State government had to lift the ban later after potato growers and traders staged an agitation, citing huge financial losses.

The new BJP government in the State has lifted all restrictions on the inter-State movement of potatoes, onions, fruits, vegetables, oil seeds, foodgrains and other essential products. Before the Assembly elections last month, the BJP had promised to lift these restrictions.

Natural gas futures: Go long at ₹288 and ₹282

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

Natural gas prices have been moving up very well over the last three weeks.

COMMODITY CALL.

The natural gas futures contract traded on the Multi-Commodity Exchange (MCX) has surged about 24 per cent from the low of ₹235 per mmBtu made in April. It is currently trading at ₹292 per mmBtu.

OUTLOOK

The recent rise is happening near a strong trendline of resistance. So, this in a way indicates that the downtrend that was in place since January could have come to an end.

Support is at ₹280. Immediate resistance is at ₹294. Failure to breach ₹294 on its

first attempt could trigger a corrective fall to ₹280 this week. However, a fall below ₹280 is less likely. So, we can expect the price to reverse higher from around ₹280. This leg of rise will have the potential to take the MCX Natural Gas contract higher to ₹310 and even ₹325-₹330. This rise could happen straight away if the contract breaks above ₹294 from here itself. The contract will come under pressure for a fall to ₹270-₹265 only if it breaks below ₹280. But as mentioned above, this is less likely.

TRADE STRATEGY

Traders can wait for dips. Go long at ₹288 and ₹282. Keep the stop-loss at ₹273. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹291 as soon as the contract goes up to ₹296. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹297 and ₹302 when the price touches ₹301 and ₹307 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹310.

TNAU forecasts near-normal South-West monsoon for TN

Gayathri G
Chennai

Tamil Nadu is likely to receive rainfall largely within normal limits during the South-West monsoon season this year, according to a district-level seasonal forecast released by the Tamil Nadu Agricultural University (TNAU).

The June-September rainfall forecast for the 38 districts in the State was developed using the Southern Oscillation Index and Sea Surface Temperature values of the Pacific and Indian Oceans, based on Australian Rainman International V.4.3 software at the Agro Climate Research Centre of TNAU, Coimbatore. The probability level is 60 per cent, said a press release from the university.

TNAU said most districts



are expected to receive normal rainfall, defined as within 10 per cent deviation from the long-term average. However, near-normal rainfall with a deficit exceeding 10 per cent is forecast for Coimbatore, Erode, Tiruppur, Dindigul and Theni districts.

NEAR-NORMAL FOR CHENNAI

Among major districts, Chennai is expected to receive 430 mm of rain, against

the normal 440 mm, while Chengalpattu may receive 438 mm against the usual 450 mm. Cuddalore and Vellore are forecast to receive rainfall on par with their long-term averages.

In the western region, Coimbatore is projected to receive 178 mm of rainfall, against the normal 210 mm, while Tiruppur may receive 129 mm, compared with its average of 151 mm. Erode is likely to record 231 mm, down from the normal 260 mm.

Tirunelveli is expected to witness the sharpest deficit, with rainfall projected at 108 mm, down from the normal 128 mm, marking a 16 per cent decline. The university said the forecast will help farmers and policymakers make informed decisions on crop planning, irrigation scheduling and water resource management.

Platinum demand for auto production up 1% in Q1, jewellery offtake down 15%

Our Bureau
Chennai

Platinum demand for vehicle production in India increased by 1 per cent in the first quarter of 2026 compared with the same period a year ago. However, demand for fabrication jewellery was the lowest in 10 quarters, declining by 15 per cent, the World Platinum Investment Council (WPIC) Q1 2026 report said.

Indian vehicle production is heavily biased toward pickups and SUVs, which naturally require higher platinum group metal (PGM) loadings to meet emissions standards.

The projections for the whole of 2026 are 2 per cent increase, buoyed by the revised Goods and Services

Tax (GST 2.0) framework. This policy reduced taxes on eligible light-duty vehicles from 28 per cent to 18 per cent, stimulating production of pure internal combustion engine (ICE) and hybrid vehicles, it said.

IMPORT DUTY HIKE

However, the report has not taken into account the hike in the import duty to 15.4 per cent last week. The doubling of the duty is expected to raise the cost of emission-control systems used in cleaner internal combustion vehicles.

The report still projects India as a bright spot for platinum demand, which is expected to be resilient and witness growth across the automotive and jewellery sectors. Demand for platinum jewellery fabrication



The WPIC report still projects India as a bright spot for platinum demand

fell by 15 per cent year-on-year to 45,000 ounces. It was the lowest since the third quarter of 2023. Slack exports, depreciation of the Indian rupee, offsetting corrections in the global market and disruptions due to the Iran war, which consequently led to a hike in insurance premia, affected jewellery demand, it said.

Despite the 15 per cent

drop in Q1 demand, the WPIC report projected a 5 per cent increase in jewellery fabrication demand. The growth is expected to be driven by store expansions by corporate retailers and increasing consumer awareness.

In addition, the widening price gap between gold and platinum will encourage retailers to increase platinum inventory, specifically in lightweight designs, studded diamond jewellery and bi-metal pieces. The other optimistic view was the hope that retail dealers could sell bars and coins with manufacturers establishing dedicated facilities. The report expects investors to turn to platinum coins as part of their portfolio diversification due to volatile equity markets and geopolitical tensions.

Energy firm SAEL plans to produce 1 GW of power from paddy stubble in the next 5 years

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Renewable and green energy company SAEL plans to increase its power generation from biomass, particularly paddy stubble to one gigawatt over the next five years, its Chief Executive Officer (CEO) Laxit Awla has said.

As part of this, the New Delhi-based company is planning to expand its paddy straw-based waste-to-energy generation to different States. It is currently operating in Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan. It has 11 power-generating units in these States, producing 165 MW of electricity solely from paddy stubble. The company is the largest producer of such power in the country.

"As a nationwide player,



Laxit Awla, CEO, SAEL

we are targeting the entire country and wherever we can do paddy straw-based waste-to-energy. So we are looking at States like Chhattisgarh, Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh," he told *businessline* in an online interview.

REALISING POLLUTION

New Delhi-based Sael has been in the power industry for about 10 years now. Over the past three years, it has grown from a portfolio of

about 400 MW to 8.5 GW on the solar independent power production side.

The company has backward integration in its module manufacturing and is coming up in the cell manufacturing space over the next one-and-a-half years. Apart from that, it is present in one of the major segments and a diversified segment — agri waste to energy.

The company has been present in this segment for over 15 years. "We primarily use paddy stubble as fuel to operate our power plants. We used multiple fuels from 2009 to 2015. We built our first agri-waste-to-energy plant, which is still running," said Awla.

SAEL used mixed fuels with rice husk, besides wheat straw, leaves and any kind of agri waste until 2015. From 2015-16, it realised that the

pollution problem is because of paddy stubble.

DANISH TECHNOLOGY

"We got technology from a Danish engineering company, BWE, which made it easier for us to burn paddy stubble and produce power and run our plants at 85 to 90 per cent annual plant load factor. This is the highest in the industry," said the company's CEO.

The first agri-waste-to-energy plant was set up in December 2019, totally based on paddy stubble. It has not gone for any other biomass or other fuel or bagasse.

Explaining the process, Awla said the burning of paddy stubble is controlled in a boiler, which also has pollution control equipment that sucks out excess particles.

Net investments in gold ETFs turn positive after 3 weeks

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Gaining sheen

(As of May 15, 2026)

Inflows/outflows	Flows (in \$b)
Global inflows	1.78
Global outflows	1.18
North America	0.83
Europe	0.18
Asia	-0.41
Other	0.07

Source: WGC

INVESTOR SHIFT

Investments in the ETFs were \$1.79 billion, while outflows were \$1.18 billion, leaving a net inflow of \$0.61 billion.

Surprisingly, investors in Asia, particularly China, chose to quit the funds, but those in North America, led by the US, invested \$0.83 billion.

Data for Indian investments were not available, but Japanese investors chose to log out to the tune of \$0.2 million. US investments were \$792.8 million, while in the UK, they were \$43.4 million.

France and Canada also saw the inflows turn positive at \$73.2 million and \$32.1 million. These countries were the movers and shakers of gold ETF investments.

EQUITY MARKETS CRASH

Investors chose to return to gold ETFs following a crash in the equities market. With gold prices dropping by 19 per cent since it peaked at \$5,608 an ounce on January 29, the precious metal seemed an attractive asset to bet on. Gold prices are currently ruling at \$4,570 an ounce.

Gold prices have dropped after the Iran war broke out on February 28.

Fears of inflation, a slowdown in the economy, a hike in bank interest rates and a rise in bond yields have dragged gold from its peak.

Year-to-date, net inflows into the ETFs were \$19.54 billion, up from 18.9 billion a week ago.

Total investments were \$70.81 billion (\$69.02 billion a week ago), while outflows were \$51.27 (\$50.09 billion).

Net investments in the US were down at \$925.2 million compared with \$1.72 billion a week ago. In the UK, they increased to \$2.04 billion and to \$1.90 billion in Switzerland.

CHINA, INDIA LEAD

China and India continue to lead the investment flow into ETFs.

Chinese inflows in Beijing were \$8.83 billion (\$9.23 billion a week ago), while Indian investments were down a tad at \$3.55 billion. Inflows in Japan were up at \$1.26 billion, while they were \$0.89 billion in South Korea.

Among other nations, the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region had total inflows of \$0.93 billion, Singapore \$0.27 billion and Canada \$0.46 billion.

Investments into gold ETFs surged early this year as the yellow metal soared. The precious metal has had a golden rally since 2024 on hopes of a rate cut by the US Fed, the US trade dispute with other countries and geopolitical crises.

However, the Iran war changed the outlook.

QUICKLY.

Hyderabad airport opens 50,000 tpa cargo terminal

Hyderabad: GMR Hyderabad International Airport (GHIAL) commissioned cargo terminal 2 at the Hyderabad airport on Monday. Spread across 16,864 sq m, the new terminal has been engineered for operational efficiency and long-term scalability. The terminal will commence operations with a handling capacity of around 50,000 tonnes per annum, with dedicated expansion areas enabling capacity to double to one lakh tonnes. **OUR BUREAU**

RBI curbs operations of Nagar Sahakari Bank

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank on Monday imposed several restrictions on the Etawah-based Nagar Sahakari Bank, including capping per customer withdrawal at ₹10,000 due to supervisory concerns for six months. The RBI's directions to the Nagar Sahakari Bank came into effect from the close of business on Monday. **PTI**

Viyona Fintech gets NPCI certification

Hyderabad: Viyona Fintech has secured NPCI certification for its technology and certification framework across multiple critical payment infrastructure layers, including UPI Acquirer, UPI Issuer, IMPS and Interoperable Banking Mobile Banking integrations. Viyona has got end-to-end payment orchestration capabilities aligned with National Payments Corporation of India standards. The completion of both UPI Acquirer and UPI Issuer capabilities gives the company the ability to participate across multiple layers of the UPI ecosystem from merchant acceptance and QR acquiring to customer-side issuance infrastructure, said a release. **OUR BUREAU**

Andhra Pradesh will play strategic role in global nuclear economy: Nara Lokesh

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Andhra Pradesh is positioning itself as a trusted long-term partner in the emerging global nuclear economy as rising AI-driven electricity demand and industrial decarbonisation are reshaping global energy strategies, according to Nara Lokesh, Minister for Education, IT & Electronics.

Speaking at the US Executive Nuclear Mission to India summit jointly organised by the Nuclear Energy Institute (NEI) and the US-India Strategic Partnership Forum (USISPF) in New Delhi on Monday, Lokesh said Andhra Pradesh was eyeing significant opportunities across nuclear manufacturing, engineering ecosystems, industrial supply chains, advanced energy infrastructure and

VD Satheesan sworn in as Kerala CM as UDF returns to power after a decade

NEW GOVT. Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar administered the oath of office to Satheesan and 20 Cabinet members

V Sajeev Kumar
Kochi

Drawing cheers from thousands of Congress workers and in the presence of a galaxy of national leaders, VD Satheesan was sworn in as the 13th Chief Minister of Kerala on Monday after the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) returned to power in the State after a decade.

Kerala Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar administered the oath of office to Satheesan at a grand ceremony held at the Central Stadium in Thiruvananthapuram. A 20-member Cabinet was also sworn in alongside the Chief Minister.

Satheesan, who took oath in the name of God, will handle Finance, Ports and Law portfolios. Having served as Leader of the Opposition for the past five years, he is widely credited with revitalising the Con-



TAKING CHARGE. Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar with Chief Minister VD Satheesan at the swearing-in ceremony of the UDF cabinet in Thiruvananthapuram **NIRMAL HARINDRAN**

gress grassroots network ahead of the Assembly elections.

Senior Indian Union Muslim League leader PK Kunhalikutty was the second minister to take oath, followed by Congress leaders Ramesh Chennithala, Sunny Joseph and K Murala-

SHOW OF POWER

The swearing-in ceremony turned into a major show of strength for the Congress, with senior leaders, including AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge, Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah, Himachal Pradesh

Chief Minister Sukhwinder Singh Sukhu, Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar and Telengana Chief Minister Revanth Reddy attending the event.

According to official information available on the PRD site of Kerala government, Ramesh Chennithala will handle Home and Vigilance, Sunny Joseph Revenue, Murala-

Among the two women ministers, Bindu Krishna has been assigned Women and Child Development, while KA Thulasi will handle SC/ST Welfare. Roji MJohn becomes Higher Education Minister and OJ Janeesh takes charge of Youth Welfare.

Mons Joseph will oversee Water Resources and Irrigation, while CP John becomes Transport Minister. The

portfolios of the Indian Union Muslim League and other UDF constituents will be announced later following gazette notification.

Besides Kunhalikutty, the IUML Ministers sworn in include PK Basheer, KM Shaji, N Shamsudheen and VE Abdul Gafoor. Among those present at the ceremony were former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, CPM State Secretary MV Govindan, former Speaker AN Shamseer, CPI State Secretary Binoy Viswam and BJP State president Rajeev Chandrasekhar.

CABINET MEETING

In its first Cabinet meeting after assuming office on Monday, the Satheesan-led government announced a series of welfare measures, including free travel for women in KSRTC buses from June 15 and a ₹3,000 hike in the monthly honorarium of ASHA (Accredited Social Health Activists) workers. It was also decided to put

out a white paper on the financial condition of the State.

Speaking to reporters after the first Cabinet meeting, the Chief Minister also announced the formation of a separate department for elderly people, modelled on international best practices, including systems followed in Japan.

The Cabinet also decided to increase the monthly honorarium of anganwadi workers and helpers and cooking staff in schools, pre-primary teachers and caretakers by ₹1,000.

The Cabinet recommended to the Governor that the new Assembly session be convened. The swearing-in of elected MLAs will take place on May 21, the Speaker will be elected on May 22, and the Governor's policy address will be delivered on May 29.

The government also appointed Jaju Babu as the Advocate General and T Ashraf Ali as the Director General of Prosecution.

Kerala Inc urges new govt to expedite reforms

V Sajeev Kumar
Kochi

Trade and industry have assured cooperation to the new State government in all its efforts for the comprehensive economic development of the State.

VP Nandakumar, Chairman, FICCI, Kerala State Council, pointed out that the State is currently navigating significant challenges, and various bold decisive decisions have to be taken. Reforms agenda in the case of doing business has to continue, he said. He also called for quicker approval of business ventures, faster reforms in land and plantation laws, stronger support for MSMEs, and continued encouragement for the start-up ecosystem through investor-friendly policies.

PRIORITISING AREAS

Vinodini Sukumar, President of the Cochin Chamber of Commerce and Industry, suggested the new government should prioritise sectors where Kerala could emerge as a national and global leader by strengthening infrastructure, branding, skill development and policy support in key sectors such as fisheries, electronics, healthcare and other high-potential industries.

Referring to the growing number of NRIs returning to Kerala, she said their international exposure and expertise should be effectively utilised to build world-class systems and contribute to the State's long-term development. Rajkumar Gupta, President, Indian Chamber of Commerce & Industry, said Kerala needs innovative thinking, bold decisions. He expressed hope that the new administration would create a positive environment for businesses to invest, expand operations and generate employment opportunities.

Experts call for faster response to CBRN threats



Upendra Kumar Singh, D-G, Soldier Support Systems, DRDO

“Through the SCOMET (special chemicals, organisms, materials, equipment and technologies) framework, DRDO has been en-

trusted with the responsibility of determining whether specific equipment or processes fall under these controlled categories. We have observed that such requests are increasing significantly in both frequency and volume,” he observed.

GLOBAL THREATS

Hinting at the international crisis arising from the continued blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, he said there are many ways to destabilise an opponent. “In today's situation, we

cannot separate military power from other soft powers or financial or economic powers... The whole dynamics of the world is extremely unpredictable at this point of time,” Singh said.

Addressing the gathering, Roli Singh, Chairperson, National Authority Chemical Weapons Convention, stated that CBRN threats were no longer theoretical concerns but have emerged as critical and evolving challenges for modern economies like India.

Rajnath begins Vietnam, South Korea tour; BrahMos deal talks to progress in Hanoi

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Monday left for a tour of Vietnam and South Korea. Prior to his departure, he said he was looking forward to visiting the nations to further expand the scope of bilateral engagement. “The focus will be on deepening strategic military co-operation, strengthening defence industrial partnerships and boosting maritime collaboration, promoting peace and stability in the Indo-Pacific region.”

In Vietnam, he will hold bilateral talks with his counterpart Phan Van Giang on deepening strategic military cooperation, likely including the BrahMos supersonic cruise missile deal which is at an advance stage of negotiations. He will depart for South Korea on Tuesday and



BILATERAL TALKS. Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh welcomed by Ambassador of India to Vietnam Tshering Wangchuk Sherpa on his arrival for an official visit in Hanoi **ANI**

return to Delhi on May 21.

BRAHMOS DEAL

His visit to Hanoi follows Vietnamese President To Lam's tour of India last week, when he met Prime Minister Narendra Modi and others.

The Defence Minister's visit to Vietnam marks 10 years of the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership between the nations, which

was upgraded to an Enhanced Comprehensive Strategic Partnership during the two-day visit of the President of Vietnam from May 5.

Singh will also hold talks with Minister of National Defence of Vietnam General Phan Van Giang, said the Ministry of Defence in a statement.

During his visit to South Korea, Singh will hold bilat-

eral talks with the Minister of National Defence Ahn Gyu-back to review defence cooperation between both the sides and explore initiatives to further strengthen bilateral engagements.

Singh will also meet Minister of Defence Acquisition Program Administration Lee Yong-cheol and chair the India-Korea business roundtable.

Both the countries are said to be working towards a third phase of cooperation for joint development of next-generation defence systems, including anti-aircraft guns, missile systems, autonomous platforms and AI.

The joint manufacturing of the K9 Vajra-T tracked self-propelled howitzers by Larsen & Toubro and South Korea's Hanwha Aerospace is one of the examples of smooth defence industrial engagement between the two sides.

Tamil Nadu CM takes stock of power demand and supply situation

Our Bureau
Chennai

Tamil Nadu CM Joseph Vijay on Monday headed a review meeting of the finances and electricity demand and supply situation, among various issues, at the Secretariat.

The CM enquired about the implementation of the 200 units of free electricity to all domestic connections with a consumption limit of up to 500 units, which was brought into effect as of May 10.

He also took stock of the various ongoing project works including the establishment of new thermal power stations, the modernisation of power infrastructure, laying of new transmission lines, and implementation of a “Green

The CM also enquired about the implementation of the 200 units of free electricity to all domestic connections with a consumption limit of up to 500 units

Corridor” initiative to better tap into the solar and wind energy generated in the southern districts.

FINANCIAL CONDITION He reviewed the financial condition of the Tamil Nadu Electricity Board (TNEB) and related entities, and also urged the Board to prioritise and implement measures to

day-to-day consumer-related grievances, including issues such as low voltage.

The TNEB authorities are said to have explained how they successfully distributed the State's peak power demand of 21.32 GW without any interruptions recently, and also briefed the Chief Minister on the current status of power generation and the ongoing initiatives being undertaken to ensure an uninterrupted power supply.

Minister for Electricity and Prohibition, R Nirmal Kumar; Chief Secretary M Sai Kumar, Additional Chief Secretary and Chairman of TNEB S Radhakrishnan; and Additional Chief Secretary to the Finance Department, MA Siddique were among the senior government officials who participated in the meeting.

In reshuffle, GCC gets new Commissioner

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Tamil Nadu government on Monday announced a major reshuffle in the bureaucracy with transfers involving the transport department, Greater Chennai Corporation and Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority, among other major government departments.

Among the key appointments is that of Gagandeep Singh Bedi as Additional Chief Secretary to Govt in the Municipal Administration and Water Supply department. He was previously serving in the Rural development and Panchayat Raj department.

GS Sameeran, who was earlier Managing Director of Tamil Nadu Water Supply

and Drainage Board, will now be the new commissioner of Greater Chennai Corporation, replacing J Kumaragurubaran.

P Amudha has been shifted to the Cooperation, Food and Consumer Protection as Additional Chief Secretary, from her earlier posting in the revenue and disaster management department. KS Palanisamy is now posted to the Revenue and Disaster Management department.

M Vallalar, who was earlier the Commissioner of Rehabilitation and Welfare of Non-Resident Tamils, is transferred and posted as Secretary to Government, Transport Department.

AR Rahul Nadh has been shifted to the Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority (CMDA) as its Member Secretary.

Tamil Nadu industry executives meet Vijay; discuss policy and investment plans

Our Bureau
Chennai

Industrialists and industry association representatives met with the Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Monday and shared their views on boosting the State's economic development.

Senior executives from the French automaker Renault Group including Stephane Deblaise, the CEO of Renault Group in India held deliberations regarding the manufacturing and engineering operations of the company currently in Chennai. “The CM assured that the State government will extend its full support to the company's growth initiatives and he encouraged the Renault Group to continue making investments within the State,” an official statement said.

A delegation from the Fed-

eration of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI) headed by GSK Velu, Chairman of the FICCI Tamil Nadu State Council, discussed measures to accelerate industrial growth and investment within the state.

Further, Ramkumar Shankar, President of The Madras Chamber of Commerce & Industry (MCCI) along with his team, also met

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Sagadevan Building, No. 17, First Floor, Dr. Dharmalingam Road, Dharmapuri (P.O.), Dharmapuri (Dt), Tamilnadu - 636701 Phone No: 9442100963
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QUICKLY.

Ground staff strike in Mumbai delays 15 flights



Mumbai: Hundreds of Air India passengers were impacted due to a flash strike by ground staff in Mumbai on Monday. The agitation called by the Bharatiya Janata Party affiliated-Akhil Bharatiya Kamgar Karmachari Mahasangh for permanent jobs and wage hike resulted in late loading and offloading of bags and delayed departure of 15 flights. A senior executive of AI Airport Services Ltd, whose workers went on a flash strike, said the management will discuss the demands with the workers. The agitation was called off in 30 minutes, he said. Air India said services were impacted due to industrial action by employees of a third-party ground handling agency. OUR BUREAU

Iran starts Bitcoin-backed shipping insurance for Strait of Hormuz

NEW ROUTE. Dubbed ‘Hormuz Safe,’ the move could generate over \$10 billion revenue for the Islamic Republic

Bloomberg

Iran has started a Bitcoin-backed insurance service for Iranian shipping companies and cargo owners that want to transit the Strait of Hormuz, the semi-official *Fars* news agency reported, citing documents obtained from Iran’s Ministry of Economy and Financial Affairs. Dubbed Hormuz Safe, the Iranian government says it could generate more than \$10 billion in revenue for the Islamic Republic, *Fars* reported, without giving a time frame or a breakdown of how the service would work. Iran has effectively shut the Strait of Hormuz — a major conduit for global energy supplies and other goods — since the US and Israel began airstrikes against



Vessels traversing the Strait of Hormuz REUTERS

the country on February 28. The government and the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps have since been looking to formalise control over the waterway, including imposing tolls and other fees. **NOT OUTSIDE IRAN** According to a screen shot of the Hormuz Safe website, shared by *Fars*, the service will be for “Iranian shipping companies and cargo owners.” “Cryptographically verifiable insurance policies will be provided for ship-

ments passing through the Persian Gulf, the Strait of Hormuz, and the surrounding waterways, and payments will be settled in Bitcoin,” *Fars* reported, citing the website *hormuzsafe.ir*, which doesn’t appear to be accessible outside Iran. “The shipment will be covered from the moment of confirmation and signed receipt will be given to the owner. The US and Iran have been observing an uneasy cease-fire since early April.

Trump issued a fresh threat against Iran on Sunday, telling Tehran to “better get moving, FAST, or there won’t be anything left of them,” according to a post on Truth Social. More than 1,500 commercial vessels were trapped in the Persian Gulf as of early May, according to the US military.

New regulatory body to manage Strait of Hormuz operations

Asian News International
Tehran

Iran on Monday announced the launch of a new regulatory body aimed at managing and monitoring operations related to the strategically important waterway, the Strait of Hormuz. The top security establishment of the Islamic Republic, the Supreme National Security Council, reposted a post on X where it stated that the

official X account of the ‘Persian Gulf Strait Authority’ (PGSA) is now operational. The PGSA introduced at the start of this month has been characterised as a new mechanism for governing maritime traffic through Strait of Hormuz. The announcement signals the formal establishment of a dedicated body overseeing developments and operations linked to the Strait of Hormuz, one of the world’s most critical maritime trade routes for global oil and energy shipments.

‘India can extend medical aid to Ebola affected nations’

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai



Soumya Swaminathan, former WHO Chief Scientist

With the World Health Organization declaring the Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) and Uganda, a public health emergency of international concern (PHEIC) — India could support the affected region by providing medical assistance, even as it ups surveillance at its own ports and airports, said Soumya Swaminathan, WHO’s former Chief Scientist. The UN health agency sounded its highest level of alarm in declaring Ebola — caused by the Bundibugyo virus in the DRC and Uganda — a PHEIC. But it stopped short of calling the outbreak a pandemic emergency, since it did not meet the criteria defined by the International Health Regulations (2005).

SURVEILLANCE POINTS

It is a very high risk for countries in that region, Swaminathan said, as it spreads through porous borders, and has a high case fatality rate (50 percent). “The public health systems there are weak and have got weaker now with US withdrawal of funding — community health workers and primary health care, most of it was funded by USAID. The fact that 80 people have died, before there was an alert, that in itself is quite concerning,” Swaminathan told *businessline*. India can extend assistance in supplying PPEs (personal protective equipment) or emergency medical kits, for example, Swaminathan suggested, as it enhances its own surveillance. “Don’t stop travellers, (but) it would be wise to put in place surveillance at the ports of entry — flights or ships that are coming from there,” she

said. Ebola spreads through contact and bodily fluids. The heightened state of alert on Ebola comes even as the 79th World Health Assembly starts in Geneva, on Monday. International health administrators are at present also grappling with the Hantavirus that struck a Dutch cruise ship; besides another British cruise ship that was dealing with a gut-virus, after an elderly person passed away from a stomach illness. These incidents are “reminders” that infectious disease threats remain, she said, and the world will continue to face them from known and unknown pathogens. Citing the Hantavirus outbreak reported from a ship, she said, Indian authorities would need to prepare if a similar situation happened in Indian waters. No case of Ebola had been reported in India and the current risk was minimal, said a Health Ministry source, adding that screening, surveillance, quarantine and case management were being reviewed. Laboratory preparedness was being strengthened, with NIV Pune designated for testing, the source added. The Ministry said it was working with agencies to monitor international travel from affected regions, besides identifying and preparing isolation and quarantine facilities.

Govt warns internet providers over betting sites access after ban

Bloomberg

Polymarket and Kalshi Inc have been allowing customers in India to sign up and trade on their prediction markets even after the technology ministry warned that the platforms are illegal. India’s Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) said in a letter last month that users are accessing “illegal and blocked prediction market and online betting platforms,” despite “domestic prohibitions.” The advisory, posted on the Ministry’s website, pointed specifically to “Polymarket and a few other similar sites,” which it said are supposed to be cut off by internet providers. The letter, which was

dated April 25, was addressed to providers of virtual private networks, which the MeitY said were being used to circumvent restrictions. The agency told the providers that they would have “exposure to consequential legal action” if they allowed access to the venues. A new Indian law meant to curb online gambling countrywide went into effect on May 1. **NEW CUSTOMERS** However, a Kalshi spokesperson said it had no comment on the Ministry’s advisory, or the volume of trading it receives from India. Kalshi’s legal counsel, Valeria Vouterakou, said the company has been in communication with the Indian

government and has not been told to shut down. In the meantime, it is taking new customers. Like Kalshi’s US-based customers, they are required to go through identity checks before trading on the platform. “We will comply with the government’s requests should they make them,” Vouterakou said. Polymarket does not include India on its list of restricted countries. A spokesperson for the company said it is “committed to complying with applicable laws and regulations across all jurisdictions in which it operates. We maintain geoblocking measures to restrict access in jurisdictions where our services are not permitted, and we continuously evaluate and update those meas-



ures.” The MeitY did not respond to multiple requests for comment. **CRICKET WAGERS** Kalshi has drawn significant wagers on Indian Premier League (IPL) matches since the current season began in March. A May 7 match between Lucknow Super Giants and Royal Challengers Bengaluru attracted \$27.7 million in trading on Kalshi and

other prediction markets would obviously fall under online money games under Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Rules (PROGA), and therefore there is a blanket ban,” said Jay Sayta, a Mumbai-based technology and gaming lawyer. Sayta said most domestic platforms stopped operating soon after parliament passed the law last year. The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) publicly cautioned investors last year that the products on “opinion trading” platforms offered “no investor protection mechanism” and were not overseen by the agency. Polymarket is in a distinct legal situation because it operates entirely on a cryptocurrency-based network. “Polymarket, Kalshi and

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Age Group	Percentage
18-24	10%
25-34	20%
35-44	25%
45-54	20%
55-64	15%
65-74	10%
75-84	5%
85+	5%